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by catradorawriterstan

Summary

In this post-finale fanfic, Queen Glimmer is slowly becoming more unhinged and taking more power. The princess alliance cracks and fractures, and soon, the characters decide which side they are on- with Catra and Adora on the opposite sides. It's a choice between order and justice, and freedom and peace.

Unrest

"Your Majesty, we've just received word that there have been more uprisings. This time from Northern Girelia, Spinerella and Netossa's kingdom," General Juliet announced. Glimmer slammed her hands into the crystalline table, causing little quakes.

"What? We just resolved an uprising in Plumeria!" Glimmer yelled.

"We did. But there's been food shortages there, and with winter fast approaching and much of their home destroyed, they are demanding immediate aid. And… the rising is led by former Horde Soldiers," General Juliet continued, stepping back quickly as Glimmer growled. Adora placed a hand on Glimmer's shoulder.

"Don't worry, Glimmer! Me and Catra can talk to them! We were former Horde soldiers too!" Adora assured her. Well, I did defect three years ago. And Catra was kind of hated by everyone in the horde… but I'm sure we can get through to them! Adora thought.

"Fine. I just... can't deal with this right now. I have enough on my plate, between dealing with rebuilding and preparing for winter. I'm sending you, Spinerella, Netossa, and Catra on a diplomatic mission to negotiate with the uprising. Perfuma, I'm sending you back into the field to grow more food. We need to replenish our stocks," Glimmer ordered, stepping back.

"But I've been in the field for weeks non-stop! I haven't been able to offer advice on any decisions, or even share my opinion! I need to help with the rebuilding of Plumeria, the rebuilding of my home, not just growing more food!" Perfuma protested. "Can't someone else help grow food?"

"Enough. The last time I checked, you were the only one with plant powers. And everyone else is busy! Scorpia is rehabilitating horde soldiers in the fright zone. Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Bow are all rebuilding Salineas. Huntara is taking control of the Crimson Wastes. All the sorcerers from Mystacor are helping with

rebuilding or helping those chipped or hurt by Prime. And now, Spinerella, Netossa, Catra, and Adora are going on a diplomatic mission to put down the uprising! So when I give an order, YOU DON'T QUESTION IT!" Glimmer screamed. Perfuma jumped back clutching the plant she had been holding. Acid pooled in Adora's stomach.

"Uh, Glimmer? You're sounding a littttttle aggressive… and we're not going to put down the uprising, we're going to negotiate with them, right?" Adora asked, shifting from foot to foot. Glimmer sighed and smoothed back her hair. The hair puffed back up.

"You're right, Adora. I'm sorry, Perfuma. That was out of line. I've been under a lot of stress lately, and clearly, that's affecting me badly. Just… please take care of this. I have a million things I have to do," Glimmer apologized. "The meeting is adjourned." A weight lifted off Adora's shoulders, and she smiled.

"So. Spinerella, Netossa. Didn't know you guys had a kingdom," Adora said, trying to break the silence as they walked along.

"Of COURSE we have a kingdom! Why wouldn't we have one?" Netossa demanded, turning around. Adora winced. Maybe that wasn't the best choice of words, Adora thought.

"I mean, I wasn't trying to say you were background characters or anything-" Adora was cut off.

"Background characters?!" Netossa yelled, glaring at Adora. Adora stepped back, looking from side to side nervously.

"Um…"

“SO, it’s nice to get a break from Glimmer, right? Given how aggressive she’s been?” Catra interrupted, stepping between them.

“What? No, she’s not!” Adora protested, crossing her arms. Glimmer was a little on edge, that was all!

“Catra’s right. Glimmer reminds me of after her mother died before she tried to use the Heart of Etheria. That was not a fun time,” Netossa said.

“You can’t be serious! She’s just a little stressed, that’s all!” Adora defended Glimmer. Catra rolled her eyes but grabbed Adora’s hand.

“Whatever. Let’s just deal with these stupid rebels,” Catra replied, leaning against Adora. Adora’s chest filled with warmth, and she laid her head on Catra’s shoulder. A faint purr filled her ears.

“How cute. Dear, do you remember when we were like that?” Spinerella asked Netossa, holding her wife’s hand.

“It’s not cute!” Catra growled.

“Whatever you say, Catra,” Netossa said. Catra snorted, pulling away from Adora and walking up the winding path to the rebel encampment. The rebel encampment. I remember when we were the rebels, Adora thought. But this rebellion was bad. Right?

They walked up the hillside, slowly moving out of the woods filled with towering trees, and onto a raised plateau. The treetop villagers from their last stop had offered them a ride, but getting a ride would mean endangering them.

Adora’s thoughts wandered, back to Glimmer. She had been short with everyone lately and had fired a palace guard over a minor disagreement, but she was just under a lot of pressure, surely.

Suddenly, a figure emerged at the edge of Adora’s vision. She squinted and saw a hulking green mass moving towards them.

Rogelio? Adora wondered. What is he doing here?

As Rogelio drew closer, Adora noticed a straggly figure tagging behind him. Kyle. They both stopped just a few meters in front of the group. Out of the corner of her eye, Adora noticed Catra's claws out and her fur on end.

"Hi, Adora! Hi, Catra! We're here to escort you back to our camp. We received the transmission from Queen Glimmer that you were coming," Kyle said, panting. Rogelio pitched in with a series of gurgling noises.

"You two are with the uprising?" Catra asked, her mouth open.

"'With' the uprising? We're the leaders! Us and Lonnie, that is. We settled here after the Horde fell, and fought in the battle for Etheria," Kyle explained.

"That's nice. Now bring us back to the camp," Netossa ordered, crossing her arms. Kyle nodded and gestured them down a well-beaten path.

"Come on!" He yelled, running down it. Adora raced after him, her legs pounding on the ground. Air moved in and out of her lungs.

The rebellion camp finally came into view. The camp lay on the bones of a town, with some buildings still intact, and others made of scrap materials built on the old frames. Tents and halfway finished buildings surrounded the outer edge, with a stream twisting through the middle of the encampment.

On the left side of town, a makeshift garden lay, with an orchard, raised garden beds, hanging plants, and mushrooms growing in mud. On the right side of town, a large compost pile made of waste stacked, and Adora thanked Etheria for the lack of an upwind breeze. A large stable and barn were also on the right side of town, with animals milling all around.

"This doesn't look like a military encampment…" Adora commented, looking around. Rogelio gargled something.

“Rogelio says that’s because it’s not. We have weapons, but we only use them for hunting or self-defense,” Kyle replied.

They reached the edge of the town, and Adora marveled at all the little details. Murals were painted onto the sides of buildings, and plants sprung up everywhere. Even the paths through the town were cobbled, with little bits of greenery poking up.

Children played with brightly painted toys, and parents looked on, smiling. The villagers talked and bartered, trading and telling stories. Animals were fenced in pens, and people tended their gardens.

As they moved to the center, Adora’s eyes darted from one thing to the next. There was a large open space in the town square, where vendors had set up stalls, and a group of children sat in front of a teacher who passed out pieces of paper and hand paints. A kind of warmth grew lay around, warm like on a sunny day.

A large building stood in front of them. The main part was only medium size, but additions, some finished and others not, hung around the edges. A set of large wooden doors marked the entrance.

“Here we are! Townhall. It has the public and private meeting rooms, the file room, a help office, and we’re currently building a library and a medical facility!” Kyle explained.

The doors parted as they moved inside, to a small entry room with a desk, a few chairs, and a large potted plant. Kyle waved them through a set of wooden double doors into a small room with a table covered in papers.

Lonnie sat on the other side of the table. Lonnie stood up, pressing her hands onto the table. Her face wrinkled.

“Catra, Adora, and Queens of Girelia. Welcome. It’s good to see you. I assume you’re here for the negotiation?” Lonnie asked.

“Call me She-ra!” Adora yelled, stepping forward and reaching up. A rock found its way under her foot, and her hand slapped the ceiling. She stumbled forward and nursed her injured hand. “Um, nevermind.”

“Yes. We’re here to negotiate. We humbly ask you to give up this rebellion and rejoin the Queendom of Girelia,” Spinerella replied, stepping forward.

“Rebellion? We’re not a rebellion, look around! We’re not trying to overthrow anything or attack anyone. We just want the princesses to stop interfering with us. They won’t help us or send us aid, they made us give them food and supplies for others and forced some of us to go work for them. And when a representative showed up, he tried to control us and ‘reinstall proper order’. Well, we don’t want proper order!” Lonnie huffed.

“Wait, so you’re not attacking anyone? You just kicked out that representative and asked for independence?” Catra asked, leaning forward.

“Yes! We’re just a village!” Lonnie yelled, scattering papers. “Oh, shit, those are important files. Kyle, clean those up!” Kyle scrambled to grab them and bunched them into a pile.

“I’m sorry, but we’re on Queen Glimmer’s authority to shut down this rebellion,” Adora insisted. Catra rolled her eyes and looked away. Adora glanced at Catra out of the corner of her eye.

“This isn’t even Queen Glimmer’s kingdom! She’s seizing power and control over everything! You want to know what our supplies and people were taken for? To rebuild the princesses’ homes and their vanity projects! Unless you can give us immediate aid and supplies, let us remain without punishment and in charge, and back the hell off, we’re not rejoining anything!” Lonnie declared, slamming her hands down onto the table, sending papers flying. “Damnit, not again! Kyle, clean that up! Now!” Kyle yelped and scurried to grab the papers, adding to his already decent-sized stack.

“Hey! Show some respect!” Netossa growled. Lonnie rolled her eyes.

“It’s okay, Darling. We’ll return to Queen Glimmer with your terms,” Spinerella said, stepping away and clasping Netossa’s hands. Netossa continued glaring but remained quiet.

“Fine. Goodbye,” Lonnie grumbled, turning back to the papers scattered over the table. Spinerella, Netossa, Adora, and Catra left.

“Glimmer is not going to be happy,” Catra commented, crossing her arms.

“Their conditions are what? You must be joking. I’m the Queen! They have to obey me!” Glimmer shouted, glaring at the full princess alliance.

“Well, Spinerella and Netossa are technically the Queens of Girelia, Glimmer,” Perfuma corrected, clasping a plant that grew around her wrist. Glimmer looked up and glared.

“Whatever. I suggest we put them down by force. We can’t meet their demands, and I refuse to have a rebellion on my hands!” Glimmer announced. What? We can’t do that! They were peaceful! Adora thought, looking around the room frantically. Mouths hung open, and a few gasps sounded through the air.

“But Glimmer, they’re peaceful! We can’t just attack an innocent village. And besides, we don’t have enough troops, anyway,” Adora objected.

“And it’s not your place to decide,” Netossa added, glowering. “You aren’t Queen of Etheria.” Glimmer sent a dark look towards Netossa.

“Fine. I just wanted to let all of you know, a settlement in Plumeria also declared rebellion earlier today. And they were led by, guess who, former horde soldiers. If you refuse to attack, I have another plan. We put former horde soldiers on a registry, so we can keep track of them. And if they show one hint, one hint of rebellion, we jail them. It’s the only way to maintain order” Glimmer suggested.

“What? Me, Scorpia, Entrapta, and Adora are all former horde soldiers too, Sparkles!” Catra exploded. Glimmer hesitated.

“We’ll make an exception for you four, of course,” Glimmer amended after a beat.

“Oh, so we should be grateful that we’re different from the others? The other former horde soldiers were brainwashed, the same as us!” Catra yelled, scraping her claws across the table. Glimmer and Catra stared each other down.

“Your majesty, you’re needed urgently!” A Brightmoon guard announced, rushing into the meeting room. Glimmer flared her nostrils.

“I’m coming. We’ll decide on a further choice of action later,” She decided as she walked out, sweeping her cape behind her. Catra growled as Glimmer slammed the door. Adora reached for her hand, and Catra’s face softened, her tail wrapping around Adora’s leg.

Adora pressed a kiss to Catra’s forehead and smiled, looking into her eyes. A stray finger ran itself over Catra’s cheek, and she kissed Catra on the lips. They pulled apart after a long moment.

“Adora. We can’t deal with this any longer. Glimmer is going to attack an innocent town, and then try to control former horde soldiers! Not to mention that she’s been completely disrespectful

to us and has tried to take power away from all the other princesses," Catra announced, looking deep into Adora's eyes. What? No, no, no. This couldn't be happening, Adora thought, stepping back and widening her eyes.

"Catra's right. I'm lucky she even brought me to this meeting and gave me a voice. She's been using me for my plant powers and is very unbalanced! I can't condone an attack on a peaceful settlement!" Perfuma agreed, gripping her plant tighter.

"You can't- you can't just leave! I mean, yeah, she overreacts sometimes, but we can't let the princess alliance fall apart again!" Adora protested.

"Yeah, my kingdom was destroyed. This isn't the time to divide up. Me and Seahawk are staying, right Seahawk?" Mermista asked, turning to Seahawk.

"Of course, Mermista, my dear!" Seahawk agreed.

"I can't believe you'd abandon Glimmer so easily! She's our friend. And we can make this work!" Bow added.

"Flower girl is right. We don't need all these rules and regulations and officials in the Crimson Waste. We're outlaws! And we certainly don't need sparkle girl seizing power!" Huntara huffed, crossing her arms. Everyone is taking sides… the princess alliance is falling apart! If I had been a better She-ra, this wouldn't have happened, Adora blamed herself, a sick feeling gathering.

"I was brainwashed by the horde. I won't see any former horde soldiers come to harm, just because of who they used to be!" Scorpia added.

"Well, I'm not just going to abandon my niece like this! There were disastrous consequences the last time the princess alliance fell apart!" Castaspella protested.

"And glimmer is my friend! I can't just abandon her! We have to keep order!" Frosta pointed out.

“Glimmer has provoked me over and over, and keeps pretending like she’s the queen of our kingdom! I’m not staying!” Netossa announced. She looked at Spinerella, taking her hand and clasping it. “What do you think, Spinny?”

“I agree, Darling. Girelia is our kingdom, not Glimmer’s,” Spinerella agreed. Adora’s head spun, her thoughts whirling. Eyes were drawn to the Entrapta, the last one to not take a stand. She sipped on her fizzy soda.

“The last time I left the princess alliance, it was a mistake that I’m still paying for. And the science is already here… I think I’ll just stay,” Entrapta declared, taking another sip from her fizzy juice.

“And you’re leaving, just like that? Please, Catra, don’t leave!” Adora begged, grabbing onto her hands and squeezing them tightly. Catra looked away.

“I’m so sorry, Adora. I have to,” Catra hoarsed, wiping away tears. Water filled Adora’s eyes, and she swam through her head, lost.

“Look at me, Catra, just look at me!” Adora asked. Catra looked into Adora’s eyes and hugged her tightly, kissing her brow.

“I can’t stay here. I can’t,” Catra said, letting go and turning away. She walked out of the room, her tail drooping. Adora fell to her knees and sobbed, sadness a raging storm inside of her.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> This is a Catra POV. There's some adjusting to the new environment, some angst, therapy, and maybe a little Catradora at the end. I hope you enjoy!

By the time they had arrived in the rebel encampment, Spinerella and Netossa were lucky Catra hadn't tried to strangle them already. All their kissing, all their compliments, all their sweet little inside jokes, and gestures- all of it made Catra burn hotter and hotter.

Why couldn't they just shut up and be miserable like the rest of them? Damn their optimism! They had left their friends behind, for fucks sake! Adora was gone, Catra realized. And Catra had left her behind.

Is this how Adora felt? When she left me behind in the Fright Zone? How could I do this to her, knowing how it feels to be abandoned? Catra thought. But when her thoughts wandered to Glimmer and her 'ideas', her jaw clenched and she kept walking. I can't go back. Ever.

The rebel encampment hadn't changed much from when they had left. A few more tents poked up around the edges, perhaps, maybe a few more additions built. Nothing much.

As Catra, Spinerella and Netossa, Huntara, Perfuma, and Scorpia entered the village, heads turned. A few villagers ran off somewhere. Maybe to warn the rebellion. Maybe to grab their children and hide. Catra wasn't sure.

Catra pushed open the doors to the Townhall and nearly jumped out of her skin when the point of a spear pressed into her neck. Lonnie wielded it, glaring. The point pressed into her neck, cold and sudden.

“Strolling into an enemy headquarters to take over? That’s arrogant, even for you,” Lonnie growled. Catra laughed. The tough expression on Lonnie’s face couldn’t be comical- despite the spear pressing into Catra’s neck.

“Yeah, we’re not here to take over. We’re here to join you. Glimmer has been seizing power and making terrible decisions. She hasn’t listened to us. I have the rulers of Girelia, the Crimson Wastes, the Fright Zone, and Plumeria here with me. We all want to join,” Catra replied, smirking. Maybe being rude to the person with a spear pressed to your neck was a bad idea, but Catra didn’t care.

“You really want me to believe that?” Lonnie asked, pressing the spear tighter. Catra rolled her eyes. This might take longer than I thought. Ugh.

“Why else would we be here, unarmed, and not attacking?” Catra questioned. “Why wouldn’t I have taken you down already?” Lonnie dropped the spear from Catra’s throat after a hesitation.

“Where’s Adora? You two are always together,” Lonnie said. Catra tried to keep her facial features from twisting up.

“Adora’s not here,” Catra admitted, crossing her arms and looking away. Lonnie shifted from one foot to the other. The pain in Catra’s chest intensified, taking up far too much space.

“Oh. That’s… hard,” Lonnie mumbled, scratching the back of her head.

“It’s fine,” Catra lied. “Now, let me bring in my… allies.” The word allies brought a slight hesitation. Were they truly with her? Or did they just hate Glimmer? She waved Perfuma, Scorpia, Huntara, Spinerella and Netossa inside. Lonnie’s eyes widened.

“You decimated the princess alliance,” Lonnie breathed. Catra’s fur stuck up. I’m not the big, bad villain here! Catra yelled in her head.

“Hey! They came of their own volition!” Catra huffed.

“Hmm. Well. I’ll tell you how things are going to work around here. And you might not like it. First of all, don’t expect any special treatment just because you’re princesses. You’re a common citizen, just like the rest of us,” Lonnie stated.

“WHAT? But we’re the rulers of this kingdom!” Netossa protested.

“Say who?” Lonnie asked, raising an eyebrow. Netossa sputtered.

“We’re part of ruling families! It’s been like this for generations,” Perfuma emphasized, clutching her hair. “And we have runestones!”

“Not all princesses have runestones. And your point? So you have magic powers and your families seized control a long time ago,” Lonnie scoffed. Perfuma’s face reddened.

“It wasn’t seizing power! They… became rulers,” Perfuma hesitated.

“Same difference. We are, however, making a council for our organization. If your kingdoms join, then you can have a seat on the council for one term before you have to run for re-election,” Lonnie said.

“Run for re-election? Who do you think we are?” Netossa yelled.

“Calm down, princesses. Lonnie’s right. Now you can either take her deal or go back to Glimmer with your head hung,” Catra said, crossing her arms. The princesses hesitated for a moment.

“I was with you from the start,” Hunatara began.

“In the name of balance- I agree,” Perfuma conceded.

“And me as well. Darling?” Spinerella questioned, taking Netossa’s hand and smiling. Netossa looked away.

“Fine,” She grumbled.

“Then it’s a deal. Here are the eight seats on the council. We can always make more later. The head of the council, councilor of development, councilor of defense, councilor of agriculture, councilor of technology, councilor of law, and councilor of communications,” Lonnie explained.

“Perfuma should be councilor of agriculture, no doubt. Huntara, I couldn’t imagine a better secretary of defense. Not that that’s much of a compliment, given these princesses,” Catra scoffed. “Spinerella, you can fly and are annoyingly nice- you should be a councilor of communications. And I’m sure Netossa would be happy to capture criminals and yell at them in court, right Netossa?” Netossa nodded so hard Catra thought her head would fall off and smiled.

“And you would be a good head councilor. I’ll be councilor of development, and Rogelio will be councilor of technology,” Lonie decided.

“What? I would be a terrible head councilor! A terrible one!” Catra yelped. What- did they think she was some stupid, stuffy princess? Catra wondered.

“Can you imagine any of these princesses taking over the job? Or Kyle?” Lonnie asked. Kyle opened his mouth to say something.

“No,” Catra admitted, shooting Kyle a look to shut up.

“So you’re the only one who can take the seat!” Lonnie said. Catra hesitated. On one hand, they needed a competent head councilor and all that power sounded great… On the other hand, Catra would probably be a terrible head councilor. Well, better her than Kyle.

“In that case, I accept.”

"The first section of this council meeting-absorption of separate kingdoms into ours. Please report," Catra ordered.

"We've been getting dozens of former horde soldier refugees fleeing Queen Glimmer's new horde soldier registry. They've been helping me take back the fright zone from a few stragglers of Queen Glimmer's forces, and we're working on rebuilding!" Scorpia reported, smiling from ear to ear.

"I've been setting up cross-kingdom communications and spreading the word that we've withdrawn from the princess alliance. Communication systems should be up and running any day now, with help from Rogelio, the technology councilor," Spinerella thanked Rogelio. Rogelio brought forth a series of happy grunts and gurgles.

"We've taken back most of Plumeria and Girelia, and completely eradicated Princess Alliance presence in the Crimson Wastes and the new Scorpion kingdom. A few bases and villages have been set up in the edge of the whispering woods as well," Huntara added.

"With my new Plumerian techniques and some insight from the villagers here, agricultural fields have been up and running smoothly! With some luck, we should produce enough food for the winter," Perfuma said, after a hesitation.

Rogelio set forth a long series of gurgles and exaggerated hand movements, followed by a few grunts for good measure. How was Catra supposed to interpret that?

"Rogelio says he's been spreading tech all around our new lands and is working on developing more," Kyle butted in, glancing

around, ready to retreat at any time. Catra itched to tell Kyle to shut up.

"I've been tracking down criminals! And trapping them with nets! And when they appear in front of me in court, I get to yell 'Order in the court!'" Netossa exclaimed.

"Wait, you track them down and are the judge? Okay, we need to find someone more competent to be the judge. Kyle, find someone! You should be focusing on setting up a system of law enforcement and justice, not handling all the criminals yourself," Catra interrupted, giving Netossa a meaningful look.

"And finally, we've been trying to send development resources to various towns from all over. We need to modernize our towns and make them more efficient and good looking. We need to start offering more services in towns, like free healthcare, libraries, schools, free food and shelter, and that weird therapy stuff Perfuma keeps talking about," Lonnie said.

"It's not weird!" Perfuma protested, turning a delicate shade of red.

"Says you," Lonnie mocked, laughing.

"'Says you'? What are you, a child?" Perfuma demanded.

"I thought you were supposed to be the calm princess. Guess I was wrong," Lonnie goaded, looking Perfuma right in the eyes. Perfuma looked about ready to explode.

"ENOUGH! For the second section of this council meeting, could each sector please give their individual reports?" Catra asked, rubbing her brow.

"Of course! I've been trying to rehabilitate horde soldiers, but we're missing files on them. It's been hard to reunite them with their old friends or to tell them their birthdays or other important information. We need someone to hack into the Fright Zone's computer database," Scorpia reported.

“The communication system is close to up and running, but we’re worried that the princesses might be able to hack into it, especially because they have Entrapta,” Spinerella said. More tech problems? Rogelio was a giant lizard. Not exactly the best tech master.

“We need one last strike to take back the rest of Plumeria. We need to capture Vine Villa, a large, wealthy town that’s close to Brightmoon’s borders,” Huntara explained. Attacking. That was easy!

“Currently, we are producing enough food for the winter, if we cut corners here and there, but if anything happens to any of our storehouses, people will starve. We could use some sorcerers to help with plant growth and harvesting,” Perfuma said. Too bad they didn’t have any sorcerers. Mystacor had aligned with the princess alliance.

Rogelio gurgled again. Catra sighed and turned to Kyle.

“Rogelio says he hasn’t been able to develop any new technology because he’s busy setting up a lab and making technology for our towns and villages. But, he has set up a lab and has gotten closer to equipping our villages and towns with technology!” Kyle reported. Catra sighed. They needed to keep up with Entrapta!

“I’ve tracked down a few major criminals in the crimson wastes! But the crimson wastes are still infested. Most people are some kind of criminal or part of some gang,” Netossa admitted. Ugh. Catra could already tell that the Crimson Wastes was going to give her a LOT of headaches.

“We’ve provided some basic development tools to villages, but we’re still a long way from properly equipping them, especially given the fact that we haven’t fully equipped our own village yet,” Lonnie said. Catra wanted to curl up in a ball. This wasn’t going well. Everyone had a problem, and Catra had to solve all of them, or else they would kick her out.

“Wow, all of you are stunningly incompetent at your own jobs. Rogelio, maybe see if you can find some fellow tech-minded… creatures to help Scorpia and Spinerella. Lonnie, I can’t help you with the supplies right now. Scorpia, maybe you could organize the former horde soldiers to strip the fright zone for parts? Maybe there are still some that haven’t been taken by looters. Perfuma, just… use your powers a lot and try your best. You’re the stupid plant princess, after all. Netossa, try focusing on the high-level criminals only. And Huntara, I’ll help you lead a strike on Vine Villa. You idiots got it?” Catra asked, her fur beginning to stand on end. There was a chorus of ‘Yeah’s. “Next order of business- what we should call Scorpia’s new kingdom.”

“Ooh! What about Scorpia land?” Netossa suggested.

“Oh, I don’t think I could name an entire land after myself,” Scorpia chuckled nervously.

“What about the Black Garnet? After your runestone? It’s simple, effective, and sounds scary,” Huntara stated.

“I don’t know, I think that’s a little too obvious for me…” Scorpia trailed off.

“Why don’t you name it after something that’s dear to your heart?” Spinerella asked. Scorpia glanced at Perfuma and blushed.

“Uh…” Scorpia hesitated.

“Why don’t you just call it scorpion land?” Lonnie questioned.

“No!” Scorpia exclaimed.

Rogelio let out a few gurgles.

“Rogelio says that you should call it the New Horde!” Kyle said.

“What? I can’t name it after the horde!” Scorpia emphasized. “What do you think, Catra?” What? Catra hesitated, caught off guard.

“Um… why don’t you ask Perfuma?” Catra suggested. Thoughts invaded her head of all the times she had mistreated Scorpia. From the little slights to the full out attacks. She needed to apologize to Scorpia.

“I think you should call it the Scorpion Garnet kingdom,” Perfuma said, looking right at Scorpia and smiling. Scorpia blushed.

“That’s a great idea, Perfuma. Should we move on, now?” Scorpia asked. But Catra was frozen. Her breath came in and out, in and out. She wanted Adora. No, she needed her. Adora had so much power over her, even now. Fire built inside her. “Catra?”

“Yes! Let’s move on. What took so long?” Catra snapped. “Next, we need to talk about… She-ra.” Silence fell. No-one here had powers even close to She-ra. With the combined armies of the princess alliance, she could crush the rebellion. But… Adora and She-ra weren’t separate. And that made it hurt all the more.

“If you don’t want to talk about this, it’s fine, Catra,” Scorpia gently suggested. Catra looked up and realized she had been hunched over. She snapped back up.

“Stop shielding me! Sorry. Stop shielding me. We need to talk about this. Right now. Maybe… if we could convince other princesses to join, and maybe Entrapta, we could… hold off She-ra,” Catra said. But the idea of being on a battlefield with Adora again… after everything… it was too much to bear.

“I don’t think She-ra will attack us,” Perfuma quietly commented. Everyone stared at her. “She hates hurting people. As long as we don’t hurt her friends… maybe she won’t attack us. I don’t think she will battle us, in fact.” A weight, and a heavy one at that, lifted off of Catra’s shoulders. Maybe I could still be with Adora… No. I can’t. I have to leave Adora in the past. But maybe we won’t have to fight. Maybe, just maybe, I won’t have to hurt her, Catra hoped, tears pushing at her eyes.

"I hope so, Perfuma. Meeting dismissed," Catra adjourned, walking away from the table. They slowly filed out of the room. Catra stopped Scorpia. "Hey, Scorpia?"

"Yeah, Catra?" Scorpia responded, smiling. Catra sucked in a deep breath. How could words repair all the things that Catra had broken between them? But she knew she needed to say it.

"I'm sorry. I really, really am. I was horrible to you, and you deserved better. You deserve better," Catra apologized, rubbing her arm lightly.

"It's fine," Scorpia replied. "I forgive you."

"No! It's not fine! I was… abusive. To you. And I'm sorry. You shouldn't just forgive people as soon as they apologize! You shouldn't forgive me!" Catra yelled. Silence hung. What did I just say? Is that what I really think? Catra wondered. Scorpia smiled at her warmly after a moment.

"You're right that I shouldn't forgive people as soon as they apologize. But I forgive you, Catra. You always volunteered to help rebuild the places you destroyed. You tried, and you tried hard to be better. So I forgive you," Scorpia said. Tears built in Catra's eyes, and a sob built in her throat. She blinked hard, but tears ran down her face. Scorpia enveloped her in a hug, and Catra didn't fight it. She sobbed, for the first time in a while.

"This isn't right. I should be the one helping you, not the other way around," Catra protested, looking up at Scorpia. Scorpia smiled warmly again.

"But I'm not the one who needs help. You are," Scorpia replied. I'm the one who needs help, Catra realized. I need help. "Listen. You're clearly sad and angry about Adora and what Shadow Weaver did to you. Perfuma can help you with some of that stuff. It's called therapy. And I think it could help you."

Catra hesitated for a moment. She didn't know anything about this 'therapy', and it sounded like an useless hippie trick. But… she

did need help, and she knew it.

"Okay," She said.

"Welcome to therapy, Catra. Do you have any questions?" Perfuma asked, clasping her hands together gently. Catra wrinkled her nose at the scents from the diffuser.

"Can you turn off the diffuser? It smells weird," Catra suggested.

"It's a calming smell. Try taking a deep sniff. It can help people who are talking about their trauma stay in control," Perfuma replied, her face serene. Catra sniffed. The tiniest bit of calm settled over her.

"Okay, so, what are we going to talk about?" Catra questioned.

"I thought we'd start off with asking you what's been on your mind lately," Perfuma answered. Ugh. Am I going to have to talk about how I feel? And about Adora? This was a bad idea, Catra thought. She glanced around at the cozy room surrounding them. At least she could talk about her feelings on a comfy cushion.

"Well… I've been thinking about Adora. A lot. And it makes me feel… uncomfortable. I don't want to think about her, but I can't stop myself," Catra started.

"I understand. Obsessing over something is very common. Could you try to put a name to the emotions of the emotions you're feeling?" Perfuma asked.

"Well… it feels bad, I guess. I'm angry at her. And I feel… sad," Catra admitted, grabbing a pillow and starting to knead it, her tail lashing.

"Do you know why you're angry at her? Or why you feel sad?"

"I guess I feel angry because I feel like she should have come with me. And I feel sad because she's not here anymore. And I want her to be here. And one more thing, too. It's really stupid, but I feel abandoned. Even though I left her."

"That's understandable. It sounds to me like you might be sensitive to abandonment. But your emotions are completely okay."

"Sensitive to abandonment? Who isn't, huh?" Catra joked.

"Yes, but while no-one likes being abandoned, abandonment is especially hard for you. And you may perceive abandonment when that's not what the person intended." Catra thought for a moment. Is that why I was so devastated when Adora left? So desperate to get her back? And then so completely devastated when I realized she wasn't coming back.

"I... I love Adora. And I'm not sure if I can cope without her. She's like the blood flowing through my veins. Even when I hated her most, I needed her. I feel lost without her. Things are falling apart. You were in the council meeting, you saw! It's all going to shit."

"I don't think it is going horribly, Catra. I saw that you were capable. You organized us. You got things done. But you can't fix everything. You have people to support you. People aren't plotting against you. Sometimes, things might not be perfect, but that doesn't mean they'll fall apart."

"But if I don't fix things, then I won't be a council leader. And if I don't stay the council leader, then I won't have any power or leverage anymore. And if that happens, then I'll be cast out." Far

too many emotions were rising in Catra. She tried to shove them deep, deep down.

“Catra, your value and worth is not determined by your usefulness to us. Or to your connections. It’s defined by you.”

“Well, if it’s defined by me, then that’s even worse. I’m a horrible person. It’s a miracle that Adora wants… I mean, wanted me.”

“Well, first of all, you were a bad person, that much is true. But you became a bad person because of all that you went through. And while you did have agency, you were ultimately a product of your environment. Second of all, you are trying to be better. And that’s what’s important. You’ve helped people, Catra, whether you see it or not. And lastly, how do you know Adora doesn’t want you too? I think she stayed behind because of her sense of honor and duty. You know how Adora is, after all.” Catra’s mind stopped dead. The entirety of her perspective had shifted. She could be a good person? Adora might still want her? Those trapped emotions rose to the surface, and tears burst through Catra’s eyes.

She tried to choke back the sob, but it escaped her lips. Catra buried her face in her lap. Perfuma’s comforting hand laid on her shoulder. It was an anchor. Catra cried for a while. Far too long.

“I’m sorry for crying.”

“There’s nothing to be sorry for. I don’t mind in the least. Crying is one of the best ways to express and release emotions. Crying is one of the best tools you have. I’ve seen simply letting out your emotions help a lot of people. Cry all you want. All your emotions are valid, remember that. Repeat it to yourself.”

“I’m not saying that.”

“Why not?”

“It’s so… cheesy!”

"No, it's not. It's important. The part of your mind that's telling you that it's cheesy is the part of your brain that's trying to shield you from your challenging emotions."

"What?"

"Repeat it to yourself, Catra. All of my emotions are valid."

"All of my emotions are valid." A heaviness lifted off Catra's chest. A heaviness that had lingered for a long time. Sadness and anger and regret and bitterness still remained… but they weren't the same immovable block that they once were.

"Now, can we continue the conversation?" Catra nodded. "Good."

Catra hit the punching bag hard. It deserved it, looking so smug. After the therapy session, there was too much… emotion. So Catra headed to the gym.

She hit it again, harder. The session confused her, to say the least. On one hand, she had realized some important things. On the other hand, Catra could hardly bear the emotion it brought up.

Thoughts swirled around her head as she swayed, sizing up the punching bag. She lunged forward, striking it, then retreated. Catra began circling it, staying light on her feet.

She landed another punch just as Huntara strode in. Catra spared only half a glance before returning to the punching bag.

"Getting ready for that attack, huh? Me too." Huntara said, striding in.

"What attack?" Catra demanded.

“The attack you organized? On Vine Villa?” Huntara asked sarcastically, crossing her arms.

“Oh. Yeah.”

“Anyway, it’s the day after tomorrow. So you’d best prepare.” Huntara delivered this crushing blow and then walked off and started lifting weights.

The attack was the day after tomorrow? No, no this couldn’t be. Catra needed more time to prepare to fight She-ra… and Adora. How could she face down the love of her life on the battlefield?

Catra continued to robotically hit the punching bag, aware of Huntara’s eyes on her back, watching closely. I remember the scars I gave Adora from our first fights. How can I give her more? Catra asked herself, tears filling up her eyes.

The thought- just the thought- of facing Adora on the battlefield made her stomach turn in on itself. She won’t be there. The rebellion has no idea. I won’t have to face her. Right? Right! I’m being so silly. Adora won;t be there. She won’t.

But the idea stayed in Catra’s head, swirling around and breaking things. Things like her peace of mind, her basic logic, and perhaps her sanity. No matter what she did, she couldn’t ignore it.

Catra heaved in a breath as she snapped awake from another nightmare, where she attacked Adora ruthlessly, scarring her deeply. Adora’s cries still rang in her ears.

I have to get away. Just for a few hours. Catra realized. She slapped on some clothes and stole a skiff, heading for who knew where. The memory of when she and Adora had taken a skiff into the whispering woods returned to her.

The urge to turn and ride into the woods overtook her. Her troubles and worries floated off of her as the skiff raced in the forest. Catra sucked in a deep breath of relief as the tree cover closed over her.

The skiff glided for a while. Eventually, Catra decided to hop off. The moment her feet connected with the solid earth, a calm rush surged through her body. It exhilarated her.

Her feet brought her along, wandering to a faint impulse. It grew stronger and stronger. She stopped dead at the edge of a clearing. Something lay in the clearing, and she knew it.

Should she enter? Catra's feet stood stock still at the edge, ready to go either way. It was probably time to head back anyway. Her panic had calmed, and her brain had emptied. But that urge, that deep, primal feeling urged her to go forward. So she did.

A gasp rang out all around the clearing. Catra's own gasp, she realized, as she saw Adora sitting on a tree stump. Adora looked up at her, her eyes widening and mouth falling open.

"What- what are you doing here?" Adora asked. One fist was clenched, the other reaching out towards Catra. Adora's eyes raked over Catra, both suspicious and filled with joy.

"I don't know. Something told me to go here. I just… couldn't ignore it," Catra admitted, still staring at Adora. She couldn't stop staring, couldn't stop looking… Catra couldn't bear Adora standing so close yet so far away. Catra moved closer.

"Me too," Adora replied, shakily standing up. Catra closed the distance between them, pressing her lips to Adora's. She leaned into the kiss desperately, and stroked her finger along Adora's jawline, shivering. Catra pulled back after a moment.

"Wait. We're enemies now. This is wrong," Catra said.

"Please, Catra… I need you. We're not hurting anyone. No-one needs to know. We can just pretend like nothing is happening!"

Adora suggested, smiling sweetly. Oh, Adora. Catra thought. Ever the optimist. Her brain screamed at her to knock out Adora and drag her back to the headquarters, or to run away, but her heart whispered something else entirely.

"Adora… just promise me you won't be in Vine Villa tomorrow. It's a town in Plumeria. Just stay away from there, okay?" Catra begged, looking Adora right into her gorgeous blue eyes.

"Why, Catra?"

"I can't tell you. Just promise me."

"I promise." At that, Catra leaned down and pressed her lips to Adora's. Her heart sang, lifting her up higher and higher. Who knew what the future held? Honestly, as long as Adora was in Catra's arms, she didn't care.

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> Adora wrestles over conflicts with Glimmer and her own guilt over her relationship with Catra. Some angst, and some fluff.

Chapter Notes

> I'm so sorry this is super short! The next one will be longer, I promise!

Adora's head buzzed with thoughts of Catra. Catra, Catra, Catra. She had seen Catra again. And she would see her again. If only Catra could be here right now, to hold her hand, and to make jokes about how boring this meeting was.

Catra… It had been two days since their reunion, and Adora couldn't wait for their next meeting. We're meeting together tonight. I just have to get through today, and then I can see her. Adora smiled absentmindedly, her mind continuing to focus in on Catra. Catra's arrogant grin, her occasional, unguarded smiles, and the light in her eyes when she saw Adora.

Catra's smiles had become far and few between when Melog went back to their planet to search for any other survivors. Adora longed to put more smiles back onto Catra's face. How was Catra now? Was she safe? Was she okay?

"Adora! Are you listening?" Glimmer demanded, staring Adora down.

"Yes! Of course! What was the question?" Adora asked sheepishly.

"The question was if you think we should beef up security around Salineas, or send the troops to distribute aid," Glimmer replied. Adora winced. Glimmer had only become angrier after Catra and the others left.

“Well, I think we should help the people of the kingdom. I don’t think the rebellion will attack us,” Adora replied. Glimmer’s face twisted.

“Ugh! Why do I even listen to you? You-” Glimmer was cut off by a hacking fit as her chest convulsed.

“Glimmer! Are you okay?” Bow asked, rushing to her side.

“I’m fine, Bow. But thank you,” Glimmer replied. “As I was saying, you keep letting your biases distract you, Adora.” BIASES? What do my ‘biases’ have to do with this? Adora thought.

“If you already knew the answer, why did you ask me? And Catra’s not a bias! I know her!” Adora protested. A fire began to burn in Adora’s chest, blazing hotter and hotter. Adora shoved it down. Glimmer was her friend, after all.

“Did you know her when she was in the horde? And I asked because I wanted to know where you stood on important issues,” Glimmer replied. Adora stepped back, the sentence hitting her like a stampeding horse.

“So you were testing my loyalty?” Adora asked, shock coursing through her veins. How could Glimmer do something so underhanded? Sometimes she’s fine, normal, reasonable Glimmer, but other times… she’s like this. Adora thought.

“Yes. Do you have a problem with that?” Glimmer questioned. Adora’s blood boiled, sending waves of heat through her body. She clenched the table and gritted her teeth.

“No,” She replied, blowing hot air through her nose.

“Good. General Juliet, any news?” Glimmer asked, turning.

“I do. But you’re not going to like it. In short, the rebellion invaded Vine Villa, and took it and the surrounding countryside. They now have all of Plumeria,” General Juliet reported. Glimmer slammed her hands onto the table and growled. Vine Villa? Was

that what Catra was talking about earlier? But wait, Vine Villa is part of Plumeria! Adora thought.

"Wait, didn't they already have Plumeria? Because Perfuma joined their side?" Adora asked indignantly. Bow shifted from side to side and looked away.

"Well, we did keep our troops there… and sort of kept occupying it… we thought Perfuma would join our side again and wouldn't want her kingdom occupied by the rebellion!" Bow explained, shifting from side to side.

"WHAT? And you didn't think to tell me about a major military decision? You didn't even tell me there was still conflict in Plumeria!" Adora replied. How could her friends keep something like this from her? I did keep what Catra said from them, though...

"That is none of your concern. If we need you, we'll tell you. Any news on the horde soldiers?" Glimmer asked. Adora suppressed a growl, trying to take deep breaths. I won't become like Shadow Weaver, Adora reminded herself.

"We haven't been able to register many. For one thing, several villages have chosen not to report which of their residents are horde soldiers. And many horde soldiers have fled to the rebellion's lands," General Juliet continued.

"Then you'll count the entirety of those villages are potential threats. Put them all on the registry," Glimmer ordered, her voice pure ice.

"You can't do that! Please, Glimmer! You can't just take away their freedom like that! We don't even have the resources to do that!" Adora argued. Glimmer's eyes flashed, and she opened her mouth to speak but closed it. Glimmer took a long breath in and out.

"You're right. And it would just trigger even more to flee to the rebellion's side. But we need something to boost morale. And something to send a message to any other potential rebels. I'll

figure something else out. I declare this meeting over," Glimmer said, planting a kiss on Bow's cheek and walking out of the room.

Adora sighed. Just the week before, Glimmer had been fine. Normal. But now… she was cold and single-minded. Adora sank into her chair, her energy long gone. At least this meeting wasn't super boring, huh? She joked to herself. Should I have told them about Vine Villa? I'm such a hypocrite.

"Hey, Adora. Are you okay? Glimmer was kind of rude to you," Bow said, approaching Adora. "I'm worried about her."

"Me too," Adora admitted. "She's been acting so off. One minute she's completely fine, the next she's-"

"Throwing a temper tantrum?" Bow finished her sentence, smiling gently. Adora nodded.

"I don't know how much longer I can deal with it. And if anything, she seems to be getting worse."

"Well, we're her friends. We have to stick around, right? Maybe we need to do something to reach out to her! Or maybe we could recruit Micah for help!"

"She'd probably just get mad at us and say that we were distracting her from her queenly duties." Adora groaned, and tipped her head back in her chair.

"We have to try, Adora!"

"Yeah, I guess. I know! We could throw a surprise party for her! We'll get her favorite food from the kitchen, get Castaspella to help decorate, and get some fun party games!" Bow's eyes grew huge and sparkly.

"YES. We need to do that! Who should we invite?"

"The two of us, of course! And Castaspella and Micah! Ooh, and I'll bring Swiftwind! And we'll invite Seahawk, Mermista, Frosta, and Entrapta!"

"Perfect! We'll plan it for the day after tomorrow!"

"See you then!" Bow walked away. Guilt still lingered as Bow walked out of the meeting room. Maybe I should have told them about Vine Villa. But it was between me and Catra! And Vine Villa is part of Plumeria, which is Perfuma's kingdom! Adora's thoughts buffered back and forth as she sat back in her chair. At least she would see Catra tonight.

Adora groaned as she got up. Getting up in the middle of the night sucked- but it was worth it to see Catra. Catra. Her mind began to buzz just at her name.

Adora grabbed her clothes and shoved them on, her mind wandering and her feet impatient to move. She winced at every sound she made as she snuck down the Bright Moon halls. The tall, crystalline hallways loomed over her, silently judging her.

I'm doing this for love! She wanted to shout.
The Wandering Woods lay ahead of her, the trees packed closely together. Her gaze turned to the stables, and she decided to grab a ride. Swift Wind would be so betrayed if he ever found out I interacted with another horse, Adora thought, chuckling slightly.

The horse, which she named Horsey(Since Swift Wind had denied her the privilege of naming him that) galloped quickly through the forest. Eventually, Adora slid off of Horsey and tied them up, walking into the clearing where she and Catra had agreed to meet.

“Took you long enough to show up,” Catra said, her words echoing across the clearing. Adora turned and saw Catra leaning against a rock, checking her nails and smirking. Adora longed to wipe that smirk off of her face with a kiss.

She ran across the clearing and buried herself in Catra’s arms, snuggling against her. Catra wrapped her tail around Adora’s waist and purred, hugging Adora back. They clung to each other for a moment.

“Are-are you okay, Adora? I mean, not that I care,” Catra scoffed.

“I’m fine. I just missed you so much,” Adora said, her voice wobbling. A sob built in her throat, but she shoved it down. She had to be strong.

“I missed you too. A little. Okay, I missed you a lot,” Catra admitted.

“I love you so much,” Adora sobbed, her voice breaking. Catra hugged her tighter, planting a kiss on her forehead.

“I love you too, Adora.” Adora cried, and Catra let her, stroking her head and whispering soothing things. Eventually, Adora stopped crying and just leaned against Catra for a while, quiet.

“If you ever tell anyone about me being a total softie for you, I’ll kill you. You know that, right?” Adora laughed.

“I know. I think I feel a lot better now. Now shut up and kiss me.” Catra obliged, pressing her lips to Adora’s and cupping her face, and Adora just about floated off into space. For a moment, everything was perfect.

Adora almost floated off the ground as she walked back into her room. She could still feel Catra's lips on hers, and Catra's gentle purr. The moon hung low in the sky, casting ethereal beams of light through the windows.

Everything was going to be alright. Adora and Bow would fix things with Glimmer, they'd rebuild the princess alliance better, and she would be reunited with Catra. Every fiber of her heart longed for Catra, and she collapsed into bed, glad as the tides of sleep washed over her.

She blinked awake in the bright sunlight. Her eyes drifted over to the window. The sun stood high amongst the clouds, signaling that it was close to lunchtime. A rumble shook Adora's stomach, and she smiled. Maybe I'll have cake for breakfast today. Just this once, She thought.

She stretched out her arms, reaching them over her head and yawned. She pushed off of the bed and opened the door. The hallway was oddly silent. Strange, Adora thought. Normally people would be bustling through here by now. Must be a lazy day.

Suddenly, Bow raced down the hallway, eyes wide and panting. He stopped and leaned against a pillar, looking Adora in the eyes. Adora stepped back, a million thoughts rushing through her head. What's going on? Are we in danger? Did something happen? Do I need to fix something? Is everyone okay? Adora wondered.

"What is it Bow? Is everyone okay?" Adora demanded.

"Hordak. It's Hordak. Glimmer executed him in front of the generals and the rest of the princess alliance. He's dead. And I can't find Entrapta."

Adora collapsed to the floor, darkness overtaking her.

Commanding Respect

Chapter Summary

> We get some more Catradora, some Catra going to therapy and working through her issues, and also Catra having to babysit for the baby Kyle and Rogelio adopted. Plus, the aftermath of Hordak's death.

Catra sat in a tall, regal chair. Fitting for her status as Council Leader of New Etheria. And yes, she did need all those capital letters. She glanced at her claws, sharpening them as guards and the rest of the council sat with her.

"Alright, bring in the visitor," She ordered, looking at the guards. Probably some defector. It might be Adora, her mind whispered. But she shoved that thought down. Adora wouldn't be here. She's too attached to Sparkles and Arrow boy.

Two guards emerged, dragging in a familiar face with very active purple hair and grease stains all over her work clothes. Tears lingered in Entrapta's eyes, and her mouth wobbled.

"I've come to join the rebellion," She announced, her voice unsteady. Catra clenched the sides of her chair. Why is she here? Is this a trick? Catra wondered.

"Well, first of all, it's called New Etheria, not the rebellion-" Catra corrected, but stopped as Perfuma sent her a death glare. Perfuma's face turned sweet enough to change vinegar into honey.

"Well, we're all very glad to have you here, but, I have to ask, why are you here?" Perfuma asked. Entrapta shut her eyes and then opened them again and took a deep breath.

"They killed Hordak. They executed him for 'Crimes against Etheria'. Some of the other princesses objected, but Glimmer didn't listen. She just… killed him. In cold blood. He was my lab

partner! More important than that, he was my friend. And Glimmer just took him away!" Entrapta cried.

Hordak… was dead. Dead. The person who aided greatly in ruining Catra's life was… dead. Gone forever. Nausea boiled in Catra's stomach, and she clenched the sides of her chair even harder. She sucked in a breath, letting the cool wave of oxygen wash over her. Wait. Was Adora there?

"Adora. Was she there?" Catra demanded, her eyes wide. No. Adora couldn't have been there. Right? The other council members exchanged glances, but Catra didn't care. Her brain honed in on one thing, and one thing only. Adora.

"No. She wasn't there when… when it happened. And I didn't see her on my way out either," Entrapta replied. She wasn't there? Catra let out a long breath and let her anxiety roll away.

"Wait a second. We've been having technology issues lately. I know! Entrapta, you can be the new technology councillor! Sorry not sorry Rogelio," Lonnie said. Rogelio gurgled.

"Lonnie! She's just lost a friend! Be a little kinder to her!" Perfuma scolded, before turning to Entrapta. "Would you like some kind of support to help you work through your grief?"

"That would be beneficial. But honestly, I would like to get back to science. I find it so fascinating, and anything to get my mind off of… what happened would be appreciated," Entrapta replied, her head hanging low.

"Wait. So… about Dryl, did you give it up to the Princess alliance or…" Catra trailed off, tapping her nails on her arm rest. Scorpia and Perfuma gave her a disapproving glance simultaneously.

"No. Dryl is still my kingdom. And will I be allowed to join the rebellion?"

"It's not a-" Catra paused and took a deep breath. "Yes, you will. And we're called New Etheria, not the rebellion."

“That’s good news, because I’m not the only one coming!” Entrapta said.

“Um, WHAT? Who else is coming?” Catra asked, leaning forward.

“Why do you want to know? OOOH, are you the leader or something?” Entrapta asked. Catra sighed, and massaged her temples. Geek Princess strikes again...

“Yes, Entrapta, I am the leader. So can you please tell me who is coming?”

“Can I mess with your chair? You should really have a more imposing chair if you’re the leader, and I can give it some serious upgrades.”

Catra opened her mouth to yell at Entrapta, but caught dual glances from Perfuma and Scorpia, who were watching intently. Catra groaned. “Entrapta. If I let you tinker with my chair, will you tell me who is coming?”

“Yes! Definitely!”

“Then who is coming?”

“Oh! Some sorcerers from Mystacor!” Great. Just great. A bunch of prissy, stuck up sorcerers were gracing them with their stupid prescence- Wait.

“Perfuma, didn’t you say you could use some sorcerers to help with farming? You can use these sorcerers to help you. And Lonnie, Dryl has lots of raw and finished materials. Take as many as you need to properly equip our towns,” Catra ordered.

“Oh! This news is so good for my aura!” Perfuma chirped, clapping her hands together and smiling.

“If that’s all settled, I’d like to adjourn this meeting. Finally. This has dragged on longer than Brightmoon security meetings,” Catra said, standing up and walking out. For once, everything was going

well. But fear and anxiety still lingered in her heart, slowly wearing her down.

Hordak was really dead. Gone. He had tried to kill her multiple times, tortured her more than once, imprisoned her, and sent her off to die. And besides that, he had created the hell of the fright zone.

The next morning, Catra heard the worst thing in the world- a knock on her house door. She sighed and ignored it for a moment.

"Catra? Are you awake?" Entrapta's voice asked loudly. Catra winced at the loud sound that had interrupted such a quiet morning. Birds had even been singing outside her door earlier. Well, they sure weren't now.

Catra walked over to the door and yanked it open, growling under her breath. Entrapta fell through the threshold, her ear pointed towards where the door had been. She looked around, over Catra's shoulder, holding her recorder in strands of purple hair.

"Rebellion log day one: Subject's main room appears to be dirty and cluttered-" Entrapta muttered.

"For FUCKS SAKE, Entrapta! One, it's New Etheria, not the rebellion. Two, you can't just fucking comment on the messiness of other people's homes, it's rude. And lastly, talk to me, not your goddamn weird recorder thingy!" Catra yelled, shoving Entrapta in and slamming the door. She huffed out a breath. "Sorry. Hearing about Hordak brought up some mixed feelings. But you need to be polite sometimes, Entrapta!" Entrapta shrugged sheepishly, and poked around the home. Catra bit her tongue.

"Sorry for being loud, I wanted to make sure you heard me if you were awake!" Entrapta squeaked. ...And if I was asleep, too, Catra finished in her head.

“Fine. What are you doing here?” Catra asked, running a hand through her hair. She winced as the memory or Horde prime cutting it off surfaced.

“Well… the whole Hordak thing only just sunk in this morning. And since I’m not really… close with any of the other princesses, I thought I’d come talk to you,” Entrapta admitted, fiddling with her recorder.

“Why not Scorpia? She’s great at listening. She’s great with everything. And she’s not a screwup like me,” Catra hissed, turning away and grabbing her arm. Had she really said the last part out loud? Shit.

“See, but that’s exactly why I chose to talk to you. You have made a big mistake, like me. You’ve lost one of your closest friends, Adora. And worse than that, you became enemies,” Entrapta replied. Catra sighed out some of her tension, letting her muscles relax. Entrapta was many things, but Catra knew she was honest.

“Entrapta? I have a question for you. It’s about me,” Catra said.

“Really? Well, I’ve collected a lot of data on you over the years, so ask away! I’ll consult what I’ve gathered.” Entrapta whipped out a tablet from her back pocket at this. Was that there the whole time? Catra wondered, cocking her head.

“Am I a bad person?” Sick pooled in Catra’s stomach, sloshing around. She wanted the answer so badly, but she dreaded it just as much.

“Hmm… the data is complicated, but the results show that you’ve definitely changed for the better. So I’d say no.” Entrapta smiled at that, looking up from the tablet. Catra collapsed onto her couch, sinking deeply into it. Please let Entrapta be sure, She begged the universe.

“Really? You’re sure?”

“Data never lies.” Entrapta’s face was steel, sure and firm. A thousand memories, thoughts, and beliefs slid off of Catra, melting into oblivion. She took in a deep breath, a weight off of her chest.

“Thank you. So much. Now, what did you want to talk about?”

“I’ve been feeling… confused. Whenever I think about Hordak never returning, never coming back, I feel… sad, I suppose. I’m not sure. It’s all very confusing.” Catra hesitated, discomfort settling on her. She had never tried to comfort someone before.

“With Adora… it did get better. And I’m happy that she came back. I guess… you could cry? Or just talk about it? Talking on your log might help.”

“Thank you, Catra. Sometimes it just feels overwhelming. I’ve always been a loner, but with Hordak and the other princesses, I started to feel… like a part of something. But now Hordak is dead, half of the princesses don’t trust me after I didn’t leave the princess alliance, and the other half are my enemies now. I’m not good with people, I know, and I deserve a lot of their hatred and distrust. Maybe if I had left the princess alliance, I could have kept Hordak safe.”

“Me and Scorpia trust you. And the other princesses do too. They’re all happy you’re on our side now. And it’s not your fault. You did what you thought was right.” Not like what I did, Catra thought. But if Entrapta can be forgiven, maybe I can be forgiven too?

“Thank you, Catra. This helped. I’ll mention you on my log. Now, you were talking about conflicting feelings surrounding Hordak earlier. What was that all about?”

“I mean… Hordak and I really hated each other deeply at certain points. And he created the fright zone and the horde. Maybe if he had turned Shadow Weaver away, I would have had a normal childhood. Or semi-normal.”

“Based on the data I have collected, I have determined that this is a good situation to comfort you in. There, There.” Entrapta patted Catra’s head with her hair twice. Catra suppressed a growl.

“Gee, thanks.”

“Hmm. I believe that you may be in need of greater emotional support. Do you feel any guilt or shame around your feelings about Hordak’s death?” Catra’s ear twitched.

“A little. I feel… a little glad and relieved that he’s gone. We hated each other so much, and got into so many fights.”

“Wait! I think I understand! You feel relieved because of your bad feelings towards him! I think I can understand the logic in that!” Hordak was cruel to me. And he tried to kill me more than once. But I think… I think I’d prefer if he were alive. No matter how complicated our relationship, Catra thought.

“Really?”

“Certainly! I must be going now- it’s time to EXPERIMENT with TECH!”

“Bye, Entrapta.”

“Bye!”

“Hey, Catra?” Asked a voice behind her. Catra whirled around, snarling. She let out a breath when Kyle and Rogelio stood behind her, holding a baby. “Hey, are you okay?”

“I’m fine, Kyle,” Catra hissed. Kyle and Rogelio exchanged a glance. “It’s just that you fucking snuck up on me in the middle of

this stupid forest. How did you know I was here? And why do you have a fucking baby?"

"Scorpia told us! She said you come here a lot!" Kyle replied. How the hell did Scorpia know? Okay, Catra did come here twice a day, but it still creeped her out.

"Okay, and why are you here? And you still haven't answered my question about your fucking baby!" Catra hissed. Kyle drew back. "Sorry, rough day." Adora still haunted Catra's thoughts.

"We found her in a town somewhere. Her parents died, or abandoned her. So we decided to raise her! We named her Garnet. And we're here because me and Rogelio want to go on a romantic vacation and we thought you could watch her!" Kyle exclaimed. Rogelio gurgled something.

"Me? Why me? I'm terrible with kids! Why not take her to one of the princesses who are… you know, caring! Who knows about babies and feelings stuff!"

"Because you're our friend, Catra. And we trust you. Plus, Lonnie would just teach her marching commands or battle techniques." Catra flattened her ears and stepped back. Their friend? And they trust me? After everything?

"Fine. But only because Lonnie would be a terrible babysitter." Catra rolled her eyes, but Kyle smiled, the smile lighting up his face.

"I knew we could count on you!"

"I already regret this. How long are you going to be gone, anyway?"

"Oh, just a few days!"

"Great."

Catra sighed as she plopped Garnet down on the changing table Rogelio and Kyle had given here. I can do this. They showed me how to do this a million times, She reassured herself.

Then her nose caught a whiff of the stench emitting from the dirty diaper. She gagged, doubling over. Why the hell did I agree to this again? She wondered. Oh, right. Because I'm too much of a fucking sap.

After a few attempts, she stormed out and dragged Spinerella inside

"Why am I here?" Spinerella asked.

"Because… you seem like the most motherly person here. And you're old. So. I thought you could help," Catra said. Spinerella sighed.

"I'm only in my thirties, you know," Spinerella replied. "I suppose I'll be needing the practice, though."

"For when you have kids someday in the future?"

"Not someday in the future. I'm pregnant."

"Shit. Who's the, you know, other parent?"

"It's Netossa's, obviously! Whose else would it be?" Catra's face heated, and she focused in on the baby.

"Sorry. Can you help me with the baby?"

"Of course."

"Okay." They both stared at Garnet for a few moments. "I hate to ask, but, like, when are you due? And how many? Do you know the sex?" Spinerella sighed.

“I’m due mid spring, so in about 6 months. And I have no idea about the sex or the number. Do you know how to change a diaper?”

“Obviously, I know! Rogelio and Kyle showed me like a million fucking times! It drove me crazy.” Spinerella’s eyes bored into Catra’s head.

“I’ll repeat. Do you know how to change a diaper?” Catra winced.

“No.”

“Okay. That’s fine. Just follow along, got it?” Catra nodded. Spinerella slipped off the diaper, rolled it up, and threw it in the covered trash bin. She carefully wet a cloth, wiped it along Garnet’s bottom, and threw it into the laundry. She powdered the baby and slid a diaper under her, adjusting the diaper tabs. “Tada. Also, this is a remarkably calm kid compared to other babies.”

“I sure hope so. I’m hopeless with kids. Hey, Spinerella? Thanks. A lot.”

“Any time.” Spinerella smiled gently and slipped out the door. “Oh, and Catra? It doesn’t seem to me that you’re hopeless with kids.”

“So… is the baby going to stay here the whole time?” Perfuma asked.

“Ugh, yes. She cries every time I so much as say something loudly too. This is going to be hell. What do you want to talk about?”

Catra asked, Garnet sitting on her lap and looking up at her.

“I thought we could talk about your childhood. From what Adora has told me about Shadow Weaver, it sounds very painful,” Perfuma said, her eyes soft. Catra shrugged, discomfort rising in her chest.

“Yeah, well, Shadow Weaver is a bitch. End of story,” Catra replied.

“I don’t think that’s the end of the story. Could you tell me a little more about what she did to you?” Catra gulped, fear swirling in her stomach.

“She… she tortured me. She hurt me. And not just physically. She called me names, made me believe I was worthless and horrible… I couldn’t stand it.”

“That sounds very hard. Could you please tell me some more specific examples? Sometimes sharing what happens helps victims of trauma.”

“No!” Catra drew back and hissed, letting her claws slide out. No, no, no, no! She thought. I can’t talk about that. I’ll never be able to talk about that. Never. Then Garnet started crying, big, fat tears sliding down her chubby cheeks. “I’m sorry. I overreacted a little.”

“It’s okay, Catra. It’s a natural trauma response to get defensive or hostile. I’ve seen it many times before.” Perfuma’s voice washed over her and Garnet, soft and gentle. Catra relaxed her muscles, and Garnet stopped crying.

“It’s not okay! I hurt and tried to kill the love of my life, opened a portal that nearly destroyed all of Etheria, and then I worked with someone who was trying to destroy my home!” A silence fell. Garnet turned to Catra and looked her in the eyes, clinging to her.

“Those are all very bad actions, Catra. But you’re not a bad person. And beating yourself up isn’t going to do any good. Being

hard on yourself is your mind's way of tricking you into thinking that you're improving. Real self growth only comes from loving yourself and changing your habits and actions."

Catra hesitated. But I don't deserve love. I'm awful! But… maybe I can be better. Entrapta said I'd changed. Maybe I can be different, just maybe.

"But haven't I done too many awful things?"

"You're trying to make up for that, Catra. That's what matters. You think of yourself as the bad guy, but you've suffered too. You've gone through a lot too." Catra hesitated, her emotions settling down.

"I... I think I'm ready to start talking about my trauma."

"Are you sure? It could be very difficult. I want you to be sure."

"I'm sure. I'm ready."

"Then let's begin."

"When I would misbehave, Shadow Weaver would take away my ration bars. She would say 'I'm teaching you a valuable lesson.'. To be fair, I was a little shit when I was a kid."

"That's not an excuse for what she did to you. Ever. You didn't deserve that in the slightest. And thank you for sharing that. It takes a lot of bravery to share something like that."

"Whatever. It's just what happened to me." Catra scoffed.

"It's more than that, and you know it. It's traumatic. And your brain tells you not to share it with anyone, to protect you from pain. But really, not talking it out just results in more pain. So I'm glad you're talking about it."

"Ugh. I forgot how precious you princesses can be about feelings and dumb things like that. Yeah, being hungry sucked. And

knowing that no-one was looking out for me enough to slip me some food sucked too. It made me feel worthless."

"That sounds horrible. Is that why you tried so hard to climb the ranks of the horde and conquer Etheria? Because you wanted to prove you had worth?" Catra froze, tensing up.

"...Maybe."

"Catra, I want you to remember that you have worth as a person. Worth is inherent in every person. Your homework for this week is to remember that you have worth. You are worth something."

"Fine, whatever. If it makes you feel better, I guess."

"Good. Now let's continue."

Catra sank into her plush couch, surveying her home as Garnet sat on her lap. Little shit, Catra thought, smiling. Her home had only three rooms, a bedroom, a bathroom, and a main room.

The main room held a little stove and food storage area, with a few cabinets for storing kitchen things and counter tops for preparing food. A small wooden table with three cushioned chairs lay in the center, underneath a hanging light. A couch sat in front of a mostly empty bookshelf next to a window.

To the left, a bathroom with a toilet, bathtub, and sink sat. The bathtub had yet to be used. To the right, a small bedroom lay. A

small double bed, a dresser, two nightstands, a desk with a chair, and a large plant in the corner filled it up completely.

Her little home held few decorations. Some kitchen utensils sat on the countertops as makeshift decoration, and a map of Etheria hung behind the couch. Seahawk had given Catra some wooden bookends and mini sculptures to put on the bookshelf that he had carved himself. The bathroom had a mirror, and the bedroom had a colorful tapestry of the Battle for Etheria some locals had given her.

And of course, plants filled up the remaining space, courtesy of Perfuma. Eight plants sat in the main room alone, three potted plants on the window sill, one larger potted plant on the table, three hanging plants, and a huge potted plant in the corner.

Garnet looked up at Catra, cooing. Catra groaned.

"No. Nope. You are not going to play the super cute baby card. You are going to sleep in the makeshift crib in here. Just be glad you're not sleeping with Perfuma and Scorpia like the last few nights," Catra scoffed. Garnet's eyes became even softer and cuter. Catra stifled a purr. "No!"

Catra stomped over to the crib and roughly put Garnet inside. I don't like this stupid baby. I hate her. I can't wait until Rogelio and Kyle come back! Catra thought. She is a little cute… But I don't like her!

Her bed lay in front of her as she entered the bedroom, soft and fluffy. She dove under the covers, in a fetal position for warmth in the late fall. The soft blanket of sleep fell over her, dragging her into the land of dreams.

Shadow Weaver stood over her, darkness seeping out of her. Her hands lay clasped in front of her. The dark designs on her mask seemed to reach out and claw at Catra.

"Hello, Catra," Shadow Weaver hissed, her voice nails on glass. "Come to watch the show?"

"What show?" Catra asked, looking at the impenetrable fog around them. Nothing here, that was for sure. Then, Queen Angella, from what Catra had seen far off on the battlefield, and from murals, drawings, tapestries, and paintings appeared.

"You were responsible for my death," She said, her face grave. Catra's heart began to ache.

"I'm sorry! I didn't know you were going to die!" Catra apologized, stepping forward and reaching out. Angella faded away into the fog, her face turning soft and calm. Mermista appeared, holding her trident.

"You destroyed my kingdom," Mermista accused, her eyes flashing. The ache in Catra's heart began to grow and intensify.

"I'm sorry! I didn't realize all the innocent people I was hurting…" Catra admitted, looking down at her feet. Mermista faded into the fog. Entrapta appeared, holding her recorder.

"You sent me to Beast Island," Entrapta whispered, her face soft and sad, her eyes filled with tears. Tears began to pool in Catra's eyes.

"I'm so, so sorry, Entrapta. I… I… was wrong," Catra choked. Entrapta faded into the fog. Scorpia appeared.

"You made me feel horrible about myself!" Scorpia cried. Tears began to fall from Catra's eyes, and a sob pushed its way up her throat.

"I'm so, so, so sorry, Scorpia. There's absolutely no excuse for what I did to you!" Catra yelled, emotion overtaking her. Scorpia

faded into the mist, and Adora appeared. Oh, Adora… Catra thought.

"You tried to hurt me and kill me so many times…" Adora trailed off, her face tired, and her limbs limp. Catra's heart cracked in two, and she threw herself at Adora, only to find that Adora stayed just out of reach, no matter what.

"I'm sorry! From the depths of my heart, I'm sorry! I love you, and I hurt you! And that was so wrong, I know. But please, forgive me!" Catra screamed, hurling herself towards Adora again. Adora faded into the mist, a soft smile on her lips. Catra collapsed, sobbing.

Shadow Weaver appeared again, her smile twisted.

"Catra, Catra, Catra…" Shadow weaver trailed off.

"What the hell do you want, Shadow Weaver?" Catra asked.

"You don't have to be so rude, Catra. I'm just checking in on you, after all," Shadow Weaver said. Catra growled, tail lashing.

"Why don't you leave me alone?" Catra pleaded, curling in on herself.

"Well, that would be no fun, wouldn't it?" Catra's heart splintered into a million tiny pieces, scattering with the wind. She got up slowly and stared Shadow Weaver in the eyes.

"You will leave me alone, Shadow Weaver. You tortured me for years. And you got away with it. You made me scared and angry. You nearly destroyed me! But now you're dead. And no-one in the entire universe feels sorry that you are. So leave me alone, because I'M NOT SCARED OF YOU ANYMORE!" Shadow Weaver faded into the fog, and Catra dropped to the ground, sobbing.

Suddenly, the floor beneath her splintered and cracked, sending her spiraling into the abyss. Catra clawed at the air, desperately

trying to stop the freefall. But eventually, she stopped, and let herself plummet downwards.

She woke with a start, sitting straight up in her bed, panting. Garnet's faints cries pierced the walls of her room. Catra growled, flattening her ears and getting up. She entered the main room and looked at Garnet crying in her crib.

The cries softened as Catra stood over Garnet. Garnet widened her eyes, beginning to coo. Catra rolled her eyes and sighed. This baby is so annoying. And I don't like her, Catra thought. But she reached down and scooped Garnet up, patting her on the back a few times. This is just so she stops crying.

Garnet settled in and stopped crying as Catra swayed from side to side, moonbeams casting over both of them. Catra hesitated for a moment. Should I bring her into my room? Kyle and Rogelio are coming back tomorrow, so it would only be for one night… Catra thought, wavering back and forth.

"This is not because I like you," Catra hissed.

Finally, she brought the silent baby into her room, falling back onto her soft bed with the baby on her chest. Garnet cooed and nestled closer, grabbing onto Catra's fur. A soft purr rumbled in Catra's chest, her first since leaving Brightmoon.

Catra and the other members of the council waited for Rogelio and Kyle to return from their vacation in the Crimson Wastes. Catra held Garnet, despite the others' offers to take her.

“How was your sleep last night, Catra? I know babies make it hard to sleep. Garnet kept me and Scorpia up all night when we watched her,” Perfuma commented.

“I slept fine. I had a nightmare and when I woke up from that, I heard her crying. I let her sleep in bed with me just so she wouldn’t cry,” Catra replied.

“Oh! How precious! Where did she sleep?” Perfuma asked, clasping her hands together. Catra hiss-sighed.

“...On my chest,” She admitted, rolling her eyes. Perfuma smiled and opened her mouth. “Don’t make a comment on it.”

“Don’t worry, I won’t, I won’t. What was your nightmare about?” Catra’s ear twitched and she looked away.

“I saw a lot of people who I’ve hurt. And I, you know, apologized to all of them, then they disappeared. Then Shadow Weaver appeared, and I told her off. Then… then I started… crying. Ugh. And then the floor cracked and I fell into a bottomless abyss. Then I woke up. So, you know, pretty standard.”

“That sounds… very interesting. It sounds healing, in fact. You got to apologize to people, and you told off Shadow Weaver!”

“Yeah, but I cried at the end. And then I, you know, fell into a bottomless pit where I had no control?”

“Yes, but that’s not necessarily bad. Crying lets out a lot of emotion. Crying isn’t bad. And as for the bottomless pit, it’s like plunging into the unknown. Healing is unknown. And it’s scary, and you give up some of your carefully made control. But it’s better for you. All in all, that dream shows that you’re on the right track.”

Catra opened her mouth to criticize, then hesitated. Maybe Perfuma is right. After I cried and fell into that pit, I felt better and even purred. Maybe crying isn’t all bad, She contemplated.

“Anyway, how are you and Scorpia doing? I know you didn’t just move in ‘platonically’, princess.” Perfuma blushed and looked away.

“Well… I really like her. She’s… nice. We’ve kissed a couple times.”

“Aww, as if you princesses couldn’t get any more obnoxious about your emotions and feelings. It is a tiny bit sweet, though. But don’t tell anyone I said that.”

“I won’t, don’t worry. And I’m sure you’ll find someone post Adora.” Catra’s fur stood up on end and she hissed.

“I don’t want to find someone ‘post Adora’.”

“I’m sorry, of course, you need time.” Catra hesitated. No-one could ever be like Adora to her. She’d loved and cared about her from the moment she knew what love was. I love Adora. And I’m not just ‘getting over her’ with time, Catra thought.

“Look! Here come Kyle and Rogelio!” Scorpia shouted, wandering over to Perfuma and Catra. Perfuma beamed and Scorpia blushed and they hugged.

“I have to say, I thought I’d be happier to get rid of you, Garnet. I guess I’ll have to volunteer to babysit you sometime- ugh,” Catra said. Scorpia gasped.

“Did you- did you warm up to Garnet? Oh my gosh, that is just so precious!” Scorpia gushed, her face lighting up.

“Scorpia, don’t make comments about me and Garnet,” Catra requested, her ears flattening.

“Of course! Of course. It’s just so- never mind,” Scorpia stopped herself.

Kyle and Rogelio finally rolled up to the entrance of what Catra had dubbed ‘New Heart’ after all the princesses' ideas had been

even cheesier. At least ‘New Heart’ could remind Catra of what had happened at the Heart of Etheria.

“Garnet!” Kyle called out, opening his arms and eyes wide. Rogelio gurgled happily, smiling. Catra’s ear twitched, and she slowly handed Garnet over to Kyle, who began cuddling and cooing to her.

“Ugh. I can’t believe I’m saying this, but… if you ever need someone to, you know, babysit, I’m open,” Catra said.

“Good! Because me and Rogelio want you to be Garnet’s godmother!” Kyle exclaimed. Catra’s ears flattened, and her tail lashed.

“Me? Why? I’m terrible with kids!” Catra protested.

“You said the same thing when we asked you to babysit,” Kyle commented. Catra stepped forward and growled.

“What are you saying, Kyle?” Catra asked. Kyle yelped and stepped back. “Sorry, Kyle. I didn’t mean to scare you.”

“I-I know. So are you going to be Garnet’s godmother or not?” Kyle asked, his tone confident despite his quivering. Catra rolled her eyes.

“Fine. I’ll be way better at this than any of these dumb princesses. And I do kind of like Garnet.” Kyle beamed and Garnet squealed.

“Wonderful!”

“Whatever, Kyle.”

“Catra! It’s good to see you!” Adora called from across the clearing, their unofficial rendezvous point.

“It’s good to see you too, princess,” Catra taunted. Adora blushed bright pink and fiddled with her loose hair. Too easy. “Huh, it’s weird to see you without your stupid ponytail.”

“Yeah, I decided I wanted to change some things up. Listen, I didn’t have anything to do with Hordak being executed. I was asleep, I swear!”

“Yeah, I know. Entrapta told us.” Catra and Adora stepped closer.

“Entrapta! Is she okay? I was worried when she disappeared. Can I help in any way? I’ve been trying to keep Glimmer calm, but… it’s very difficult to say the least.”

“Relax, princess.” Catra moved closer to Adora, curling a lock of her hair around her fingers and looking into Adora’s crystal blue eyes. Catra heard Adora’s breath catch. She leaned down and kissed Adora, her lips soft and gentle. Catra pressed closer, her tail wrapping around Adora’s leg. Catra left a trail of kisses on Adora’s neck before coming back up/ “Feeling better?”

“Yes.” Adora looked into Catra’s eyes for a moment before Catra leaned onto Adora’s chest and began to purr gently. “You’re purring? You haven’t done that in a while. What’s been going on with you?”

“You would be surprised. I had heart to hearts with some people, unfortunately. And I’m… talking with Perfuma. About some of the stuff I’ve gone through. Also, Rogelio and Kyle are a thing, they adopted a baby, and I became her godmother after I babysat her.” Adora pulled back from their embrace.

“Wait, what?” Catra gently pulled Adora back in, beginning to play with her hair. “You’re a godmother?”

“I was surprised too. Yeah, I babysat her. It was a better experience than I expected.” Catra and Adora held each other for

a few more moments. “Adora. I… need to apologize.”

“For what?” Adora’s eyes trained themselves on Catra.

“For everything. For the portal, for all the times I tried to hurt you… for Horde Prime.”

“You’ve apologized before.”

“I want to apologize again. I’m so, so sorry, Adora.”

“I forgive you. And I love you Catra. That isn’t changing anytime soon.”

“I love you too.” Catra planted a kiss on Adora’s head and they both stared up at the stars in each others arms for a long, long time.

Discoveries

Chapter Summary

In this chapter, Adora discovers why Glimmer has been acting the way she has, Catra and a few others sneak into Brightmoon, there's a weird witch lady, carrot cake slander, and the rebellion gets a new member. Enjoy!

Catra peered over Entrapta's shoulder as the sound of furious typing filled her ears. The strange mix of numbers, letters, and symbols muddied her head, and she stepped back and groaned.

"How much longer until you hack it? I'm getting really bored," Catra said. Entrapta glanced back at her, her purple strands of hair still typing.

"Just a few minutes!" She chirped, turning back to her work.

"So. Ever been this bored before?" Catra asked Huntara, who stood near the door in Entrapta's new laboratory in New Heart.

"Once I went six months without bashing someone's face in," Huntara replied. Catra's eyes widened, and she made a mental note to not get onto Huntara's bad side. Ever.

"That sounds like a problem. Would you like to do a guided meditation to help with your anger issues?" Perfuma asked.

"No thanks, Flower girl," Huntara scoffed.

"You call her Flower girl too? I used to call her that!" Catra exclaimed.

"Catra, Huntara! That's not very nice!" Scorpia scolded.

"Why didn't I know you were part of the princess alliance before? I would have joined so much sooner if I had known that it wasn't all prissy princesses!" Catra said aloud.

“Thanks, Cat girl. You’re not so bad yourself,” Huntara replied.

“I cracked it!” Entrapta squealed, spinning around in her chair.

“You did? What does it say?” Catra demanded.

“Well, this is just the opening page. I’m just going to navigate through this and… there! The classified section,” Entrapta emphasized. Her eyes pored over the screen, growing bigger every second. “Oh, no…”

“What?” Catra asked, tensing.

“You’d better read this yourself,” Entrapta suggested. Catra shot over, her eyes glued to the screen. Her brain scrambled to process everything on the screen as her eyes raced over the page.

Shit,” She breathed as soon as she understood. People had started speaking out against Queen Glimmer. And she had responded by imprisoning them. And more people sat on a watchlist- to be monitored for possible ‘seditious’ activities. But it got worse. Melog had returned from his mission to Critus. And Glimmer was holding him in a jail cell.

Melog. In a jail cell. Catra’s stomach twisted, and she stumbled away, tearing up. Fuck. What am I going to do?

Adora paced back and forth, her mind racing. Glimmer hadn’t spoken to her since the execution. Shock had overtaken Adora, and she had left on a several day long mission away from Brightmoon in Salineas.

“Hey, Adora. Good to see you. Been a while, since you ran away to Salineas after the whole hordak thing,” Mermista snapped as she saw Adora. Adora winced. Maaaaybe I should have at least told people I was leaving… Adora thought.

“I’m sorry. I just couldn’t deal with Glimmer after she executed Hordak. I had to leave,” Adora admitted. Mermist stared at Adora for a long moment, crossing her arms.

“Whatever. It’s just soooooooo fucking frustrating, because half the time it’s suuuuuper boring meetings and paperwork, and the other half of the time I’m dealing with Glimmer slipping off the edge. I should be in Salineas, rebuilding my home,” Mermista replied, shutting her eyes and tensing.

“Did you try to stop her? From executing Hordak?” Adora asked.

“We all did. We almost stopped her. She was going to turn away, to let him rot in a jail cell. But then he insulted her. He said ‘Preying on a helpless prisoner? I wouldn’t expect anything less from you. Especially given your mother and father.’ and she fucking snapped. She turned and blasted his fucking head off before anyone could stop her. That’s why she didn’t invite you. You would have been able to stop her.” If only I had woken up a little earlier… no. This isn’t my fault. It’s Glimmer’s, Adora thought, grimacing.

“How has everyone been?”

“Awful. Frosta’s teen angst has been ramping up, especially since Spinerella and Netossa left. And Seahawk has even stopped belting Sea shanties, which is good, because his Sea Shanties are fucking annoying, but also bad, because he always sings Sea Shanties. Castaspella has been spending way more time in Mystacor, especially after some sorcerers left to join the rebellion. Bow and Micah have been trying to help Glimmer. They’ve been the only people who can get through to her. And we’ve all been worried about Entrapta.”

Adora hesitated. Should I tell them about Entrapta? They should know that she's safe, but what if I jeopardize me and Catra? I can't stop meeting with her. I can't, Adora thought, her stomach rolling.

"Wait. I know that Entrapta is okay. She hacked into my tablet and messaged me. She said that she could only communicate with me because… because… she… was worried that Glimmer would know she messaged us if she messaged all of us!" Mermista raised an eyebrow and stepped closer. Adora tensed, her hairs standing on edge.

"Are you just saying that to make us feel better?" Adora let out a breath as quietly as she could. They don't suspect I'm in communication with our enemies. Thank Etheria. Well, I mean, they aren't really our enemies, but they kind of are… ugh, why do things have to be so complicated???? Adora wondered.

"No, no, I swear, it's true! I'm not lying."

"Hmm. Well, anyway, what did you do in Salineas?"

"I… may have broken some antiques. But I swear, I totally helped with the rebuilding efforts! I turned into She-ra and helped lift a bunch of stuff! That counts for something, right?"

"URRRGHHHH. Whatever. It's not like I care. Are you going to, like, try to talk to Glimmer?"

"Maybe. I wish I could just punch things out instead of having to talk through them. Or I wish I had someone like Bow to talk to. Bow is the real friendship guy."

"Oh, wow, thanks."

"Oh! But you're great too, Mermista!"

"...Thanks. Adora, you just need to talk to her. Find out why she did what she did. Try to patch things through. Maybe we can get through to her."

“You’re right! I’m going to talk to Glimmer, and it’s going to go great.” It has to. There’s no question, Adora thought. Right?

“Catra, we can’t just go rescuing people willy-nilly! That’s now how it works! We have to plan things out!” Lonnie protested. Catra gave her a look and growled.

“I. Don’t. Give. A. Fuck. We’re going to rescue them,” Catra replied, facing the council.

“It seems like you have a personal stake in the matter,” Perfuma commented. Catra’s tailed lashed.

“I do. They’re keeping Melog prisoner,” Catra admitted, her eyes closing and her hands gripping onto the table, keeping her grounded.

“But how would we rescue them? I mean, Brightmoon has probably improved security from when I snuck in,” Scorpia added.

“I don’t know. But we can think of something, right?” Catra asked.

“We’d need a distraction…” Lonnie mused.

“Ooh! Can I blow something up?” Entrapta asked, her eyes sparkling.

“Blowing things up? Count me in!” Netossa exclaimed. She suddenly looked at Spinerella. “I mean, if that’s okay with you, dear.” Spinerella rolled her eyes, hand on her stomach.

“Just be safe, dear,” Spinerella responded.

"YES!" Netossa yelled.

"We could sneak in under the cover of night and make the explosion look like a tech accident. They aren't very proficient with tech, so they probably won't question it. Could you make it look like a freak accident, Entrapta?" Catra wondered.

"Yes! Probably! Possibly. Now, if I had Netossa's help, and we managed to create an explosion, trap it in one of Netossa's nets, and have Netossa throw it near some tech at Brightmoon, then things might get interesting," Entrapta said.

"Okay, and we'd need someone to help open the jail cells and take out the guards in case they don't go running to the explosion. We could wear masks and use some kind of knockout gas, and then open the jail cells using their keys," Catra mused.

"But what if they don't have the keys?" Perfuma questioned.

"I know! I could use my powers to blast open the jail cells! And everyone will be too busy investigating the source of the explosion to know! But I remember helping to build the holding cells. They're underground, and if we blast open the doors of walls, the guards will be able to sound the alarm before we knock them out!" Scorpia said.

"Wait! The holding cells are made out of wood! I can use my powers to open holding cells just a little, and I'll make a tunnel down there. We'll open the holding cell walls just a little, pop the knockout gas in, and wait until it knocks out the guards!" Perfuma replied. Scorpia blushed and smiled at her.

"And I'm coming with you. Lonnie will be our lookout, to make sure no-one tries to enter the area or is around to hear the blasts. Spinerella will stay with Netossa and Entrapta to help them get away if they need to. Huntara, Kyle, and Rogelio will be our getaway drivers. Got it?" Catra asked. Everyone nodded. "Then that's our plan. Meeting adjourned."

"But it's my birthday! Aren't we going to celebrate it?" Kyle asked.

“We have more important things to worry about!” Catra hissed, her mind on melog. But then she sighed out a long breath. “You know what, Kyle? If you stop bothering us, I’ll get you a cake from the fucking bakery, ok?”

“Great! I’ll come along!” Kyle replied. Catra flattened her ears.

“Great.”

“Oooh, carrot cake! That looks good!” Kyle squealed, looking at cakes in the display window. Catra rolled her eyes, hard.

“For fucks sake, Kyle! It’s carrot cake! What kind of sicko puts a vegetable in a cake?” Catra asked.

“Well, I like it!” Kyle responded.

“Please, just choose something actually meant for eating,” Catra said.

“Carrot cake IS meant for eating!”

“No, it’s not!” Catra sighed out a long breath.

“Ugh. I’m having a really bad day, Kyle. Get the cake, I don’t care, just don’t pretend like it’s actually fit for consumption.”

“Want to talk about it?”

“What are you, a princess? First you adopt a baby, then you start talking about feelings and shit?” Catra’s tail lashed for a few moments as they stood in silence.

“Do you want to talk?”

"...Yes."

"What's bothering you?"

"A lot. Being apart from Adora is torture. And now Melog is stuck in some fucking prison! And I have no idea if he's okay!"

"That sounds tough. But you're taking action. You're going to rescue him. And I bet Glimmer wouldn't hurt him just to get to you." Tears pooled in Catra's eyes, and she wiped them away and sniffed.

"Thanks, Kyle. Who knew talking to you of all people would make me feel better? I guess you're not completely idiotic."

"Yeah! Now that I'm out of the Horde, I'm not so useless at doing things anymore! It's a nice feeling."

"You felt useless in the Horde?"

"Yeah. To be fair, I was pretty useless!" Catra hesitated.

"Still. That sounds… rough. I guess."

"Did you just empathize with me? With no ulterior motive?"

"Hey. Don't get used to it! And how do you know I'm not just trying to convince you to get some self-worth and not get the carrot cake?"

"Thanks, Catra. You know what? I think I'll get the double chocolate cake instead!"

"Oh thank The First Ones. Carrot cake is a crime against Etheria."

Adora peeked her head around the corner to the corridor that Glimmer lived on. She sucked in a deep breath. I can do this, She reminded herself. Just pretend it's a battle!

Wait, no, I can't do that. I have to be nice. I'm her friend. So maybe pretend it's a battle where I have to be nice? But what kind of battle is that? Ugh, I'm just going to talk to her. This better work, Adora thought.

She sighed and turned the corner, walking into the corridor. Two guards stood posted in front of Glimmer's room. Adora walked up to them.

"I'm here to see Glimmer!" Adora announced.

"Queen Glimmer isn't taking visitors right now," One of the guards responded, staring down Adora.

"But I'm her friend! She won't mind!" Adora protested.

"No. Visitors," The guard replied, their voice solid ice.

"Why?" Adora asked.

"It doesn't matter why. Come. Back. Later," The guard ordered.

"Alright, fine, I'm going…" Adora retreated a few steps and then turned around, barreling past the guards, and knocking herself through Glimmer's doors. She fell onto Glimmer's floor and looked up. Her eyes widened and her heart stopped.

Glimmer stood hooked up to a machine that fed red liquid into her veins while she sat in a plush chair. Glimmer stood up and stumbled back, ripping the machine's connection from her.

“Your majesty! We tried our best to keep her out, she forced her way in!” The second guard defended themself.

“Leave us alone,” Glimmer ordered, squeezing her eyes shut for a moment. The guards hesitated, then left.

“Glimmer! What is that? What are you doing?” Adora demanded, getting up and moving closer. “Is this why you’ve been acting so strange?” A single tear escaped Glimmer’s eyes.

“...Yes. I’m fucking sick. I investigated a First Ones ruin a few weeks after we defeated Horde Prime. There was this crystal… and it called me to it. I picked it up, and then it infected me. It hurt a lot. I started noticing this green hue to the blood in my hand a few weeks after that. Micah and Castaspella know, and they’ve been covering it up. And it’s spreading. It’s interfering with everything. My body, my magic, and ME. I’ve been trying this treatment to fix it, but it’s been slowing it down at best.” Adora shut up for a good ten seconds.

“Um, WHAT?!” She yelled. Glimmer winced.

“It’s a lot, I know.”

“How can we fix this? How can I fix this? What’s going to happen to you? Why didn’t you tell me? I could have healed you!”

“YOU CAN’T FIX THIS, ADORA!” Glimer’s voice rang around the chamber. Adora drew back. “I’m sorry. But you can’t. Remember that First Ones virus that infected She-ra in Dryl and at the Northern Reach? I can’t let that happen to you. And we don’t know what’s going to happen to me.”

“That was the old She-ra! This probably won’t infect the new She-ra!”

“Are you willing to take that chance?”

“Yes!”

“Well, I won’t let you.”

“You don’t get to decide that!”

“Excuse me? Yes, I do! I get to decide who heals me.”

“But I have to help!” Glimmer hesitated, then began to pace, muttering something to herself. “What?”

“There might be a cure. Maybe if you went to the place you could find something to cure it. Maybe.”

“That’s a great idea! Wait. One problem. We don’t know what’s happening to you. I could kill you, or worse.”

“Maybe someone in one of the nearby villages knows about it. You could ask them. Maybe something similar happened to one of them.”

“Ok. Great plan! I’ll go first thing in the morning!” I can do this, Adora thought. I can save Glimmer. Or is it already too late?

“Hello, village people! It is I, She-ra!” Adora called out as she strolled into the village. A few villagers squealed and ran out to see her. Great start so far! Adora thought.

“She-ra! It’s good to see you… but why are you here?” One of the village leaders asked, fiddling with their hands.

“I’m here to…” Adora trailed off. I did not think this through. How am I supposed to say, ‘Okay, the Queen is dy- I mean sick! She’s sick, and I really need to learn about an obscure First Ones ruin!’ How the fuck am I supposed to say that? Adora scolded herself. “Uhh… so, someone. Yeah, yeah, someone at the palace is sick because they touched something in a First Ones ruin around here and now they’re infected by it? So do you have any idea about what it is?” Adora smiled, hoping that she seemed convincing.

“Uhh… no. But the village weir- I mean wise lady! The village wise lady knows every single story and legend about Etheria, ever. She lives in the house that… sticks out. A lot. It just… really messes with the village aesthetic, you know? Maybe you can convince her to… update it a little?” The village leader asked.

“Of course! I’m She-ra! I’m sure she’ll listen to me!” Adora said.

“Great! She lives at the end of that road. You can’t miss it. And when I say that, I mean you really can’t,” The village leader emphasized. “I mean, would it really kill her to just neaten the place up a little? Just once in a moon alignment?”

“Oookayyyyy… I’m going to leave now! Thanks for the help…” Adora trailed off as she backed away, making awkward finger guns.

She turned and walked down the neat cobblestone path and beautiful, sparkling clean houses. Perfectly trimmed shrubbery, trees, flowers, and garden ornaments and seating filled the gardens of the different families. The window panes shone so brightly you couldn’t look directly at them.

As the last house came into view, Adora understood the village leader’s statements. The house loomed over everything else, painted dark with sharp angles everywhere. Wild rose bushes and herbs filled the garden, uncontained.

Adora walked towards it, up onto the porch, and used the metal door knocker. The door slowly creaked open, and Adora jumped

back as she saw the face before her.

“How can I help you, my dear?” A soft voice asked, their eyes soft and their fingers gnarled.

“I’m She-ra! So I wondered… maybe I could ask you some questions?”

“That’s very interesting, dear. Do you want to come inside?”

“Yes! That would be great!”

“Do you like the tea?” The woman asked, gesturing towards the cup Adora sipped on

“Yes. It’s delicious. But who are you? I don’t know anything about you.” Adora said.

“My name is Cara. I’m a witch, dear. I can peer into the past, should I so wish.”

“But I thought only sorcerers and princesses had power?”

“That’s wrong. Those princesses without a runestone have magical power, don’t they? Not to mention Prince Peekablue or Madame Razz. And ever since you stopped the Heart of Etheria, there are even more like us, and we’re even more powerful.”

“You know Madame Razz?”

“I do. We’ve been friends for years. Though she often confuses me for someone else. We’ve practiced a good deal of magic together, and she’s even the godmother to my children.”

“You have children?”

“Yes. They’re twins, talented and magical, just like me. They have natural magic as I do, but both decided to become sorcerers in addition to learning natural magic. But now, with the rebellion, they’re been split apart. One of them joined the rebellion, the other one stayed behind. It would sadden my wife so to see it if she were still alive.”

“Don’t worry. I’m going to make sure that your children will be able to be friends again. I promise.”

“Hmm. That’s a big undertaking. Make sure that you don’t lose sight of yourself in the process.”

“But I have to solve this! I’m She-ra! That’s my duty!”

“I used to think a lot about duty. I arranged to marry one I did not love out of duty, and I always made sure to keep my self looking respectable. I used my talents for whatever other people wanted. But eventually, I stopped. I found my wife, had my children, and carved out a life for myself here. You can carve out a life for yourself too.”

“Well… there is someone I really love. And I have a lot of friends, too. And maybe I could pick up a few hobbies that I want to try out…”

“That’s good. Just hold onto that. Remember that. Now, why are you here, dear?”

“Ummm… so my friend Glimmer is cursed. I think. By an old first ones ruin from around here that she touched. And it’s affecting her as a person and her princess magic, not just her health.”

“Ah. You came to the right person. The village people think I know so much about the past because I collect stories. And I do. But stories don’t tell everything. So I use my magic. And if we’re talking about the First Ones ruin half an hour’s walk outside of

town, I've peered into the past of that. But it's history happened so long ago, it's hazy and exhausted me completely."

"What did you see?"

"The First Ones made it to infect magic. It slowly takes over them, infecting them. It infects every part of them. And the only way to stop it is to destroy it completely."

"Destroying it completely! That sounds easy enough! Destroying things is something I'm actually good at!"

"Well, good luck, Dear." Adora began to walk out, then turned back.

"Wait. Cara, what should I do about my friend? Before I can figure out how to cure her and stop the infection?"

"You need to make sure she knows not to treat you wrong."

"Thank you. I needed to hear that."

"Anytime, Dear. Anytime."

"Everyone is in position, Catra. Should we tell Entrapta, Netossa, and Spinerella to trigger the explosion?" Scorpia asked. Catra hesitated. This had better work, She thought, her stomach churning.

"Yes," Catra affirmed, clenching her fists. Scorpia tapped on her tablet, and Catra heard a ping. A few seconds passed, then… an

explosion. “Okay, Perfuma, go, go, go!”

Perfuma, Catra, Lonnie, and Scorpia hopped out of the van Huntara had driven there. Perfuma moved her hands and pushed them forwards, making a tunnel into the ground. Everyone rushed in as she created the tunnel.

“Lonnie! You have the knockout gas, right?” Catra asked as they raced down the tunnel at top speed.

“I do, don’t worry, Catra. It’ll be fine,” Lonnie assured her. Catra huffed as they continued down the tunnel of roots. Eventually they stopped, at a small hole peering into the prison room. Catra gave the signal to Lonnie, who nodded and tossed the gas can in. It began shooting out knockout gas, and within seconds, everyone in the prison lay asleep.

“Everyone, go! Lonnie, you’ll be the scout. Me, Scorpia, and Perfuma will get the prisoners out,” Catra ordered, hopping through the hole into the prison as Perfuma widened it. This’ll be fine. I helped build this prison. The bars are weak, Catra reassured herself.

About a dozen prisoners, including Melog, the only one not asleep, lay in the prison. Catra ran over the melog’s cell, picking the lock and throwing open the door. Melog leaped towards Catra, knocking her down and licking her hair.

“I love you too, buddy,” Catra said, smiling and wiping her eyes. A wave of relief washed over her, and for a moment, everything was okay.

“I missed you. This prison has been a terrible experience. I hope that we are leaving?” Melog asked.

“Yes, we’re leaving. And you’ll never have to come back again,” Catra replied, tears forming in her eyes as she embraced Melog. After a moment, she got up and left Melog’s cell with Melog.

“Stand back!” Scorpia yelled. She blasted open the prison doors, causing an explosion that sent pieces of metal flying everywhere. Everyone rushed in and began ferrying the prisoners in two trips. As they gathered the last of the prisoners, Lonnie piped up.

“Shit! There’s a bunch of guards coming over here! Hurry!” Lonnie hissed. Scorpia and Perfuma grabbed the last of the prisoners and rushed down the tunnel, leaving Catra, Lonnie, and Melog to stop the guards. The guards walked into the room, and some of them dropped their weapons when they saw the scene before them.

“Surprise,” Catra taunted before launching herself at them. She kicked one guard in the face, sending them falling to the floor, knocked out. Another guard charged at her, but Catra tripped them, hitting them on their way down and then shoving their face into the ground, hard.

She whirled around, to see Frost standing in the doorway. Catra unsheathed her claws, but Frosta threw her hands up.

“Wait! I’m not here to stop you. I really miss Spinerella and Netossa. They’re… like my moms. Really annoying moms, but still. And Glimmer scared me when she killed Hordak. I need to come with you.”

“You’re welcome with the rebellion. And for what it’s worth, Netossa and Spinerella really missed you too. They complain about it. Constantly. Come on, we have to go now! They’ll probably send more guards any second!” Frosta nodded, and they all rushed back up through the tunnel

When they exited the tunnel, they began to hear Brightmoon’s new alarm system, working well and very loudly. Spinerella, Netossa, and Entrapta piled into Huntara’s van, and Frosta, Lonnie, and Catra joined them.

The vans revved up and fled just as Brightmoon guards began spilling out of the castle, weapons ready. Catra let out a long breath in the back of a van, slumping against the wall.

Spinerella and Netossa reunited with Frosta, hugging her and sobbing while she admitted she missed them too. Princesses are so annoying with their feelings, Catra thought, but a bit of warmth grew in her chest at the sight of their reunion.

“That was a close one,” Lonnie commented. Too exhausted to say anything, Catra simply nodded, closing her eyes as she curled up with Melog.

Adora woke up to rays of sunlight gently spilling over her room. What a strange dream I had last night. Why was the Brightmoon alarm playing in the background? How strange, Adora pondered.

She yawned and got up, throwing on some clothes. She pushed open the doors, entering the hallway. Her feet bounced against the floor as she walked to the conference room, a spring in her step. As she pushed on the conference room doors, they swung open, revealing Glimmer hunched over the conference table.

“They escaped. The rebellion took all of our prisoners. We have to strike back,” Glimmer growled. Adora stumbled back, her mind whirling.

“What?”

This is War

Chapter Summary

The two sides are still at war, and it's beginning to take a toll on Catra and Adora's relationship. Besides that, Frosta is introduced into the rebellion, Glimmer and Adora have a fallout, Adora tries to cure Glimmer, and someone finds out Catra's secret.

“WHAT?” Adora asked, her head spinning as she stumbled back. “Did you say prisoners?” Glimmer fiddled with her hands.

“...Yes. There have been some of my subjects who have been exhibiting rebellious and anti-crown behaviors. So I put them in prison,” Glimmer responded.

“So you put them in prison? You can’t just imprison people who don’t like you Glimmer! That’s wrong! And we just talked about what was going on with you, and you seemed so clear-headed…” Glimmer’s facial features contorted for a few moments before going back to normal.

“Being a ruler is hard! You have no idea what it’s like!” Adora recoiled, and Glimmer hesitated. “Look. I know it might have been the wrong decision, but I’m infected!”

“That’s not an excuse! There were plenty of times when you knew well enough to let them go! And you’re still in there, I know it!”

“That’s not… well… URRGHHH!” Glimmer’s nostrils flared, and she clenched her fists. “You’re… you’re right. I can’t make excuses for my behavor, and I’m sorry. I really am.”

“Then prove it. Stop imprisoning people. And how did you find the people to imprison, anyway?”

“I had them on a registry.”

“Then destroy the registry. You have to.” Glimmer flinched, and Adora let her shoulders relax. She continued in a softer tone. “Please, Glimmer. You need to do this. You can’t keep making excuses for yourself any longer.” Glimmer hesitated for a moment.

“You’re right. I’ll destroy them.”

“Good.” Adora began to walk out of the room.

“Adora? I’m sorry.” Glimmer’s head drooped.

“I know, Glimmer. Just do better.” Adora sighed and walked out.

Catra grinned and laughed as she and Melog ran through the forest, hunting for prey. Well, not really, given all the noise they made. Eventually, they collapsed onto a pile of brush, panting and smiling. After a second to catch her breath, Catra spoke.

“I’m getting hungry. You want to actually try to catch something?”

“What do you mean, actually trying to catch something? I thought running around wildly and making huge amounts of noise was how you caught prey,” Melog replied. Catra stared at Melog for a moment.

“Did you just make a joke?”

“I did. We found a few more of my kind on Critus, and they taught me to joke. I was under the impression that joking was a strange human condition.” Catra snorted at that.

“Well, you’ve still got a long way to go, buddy.”

“Oh, well. Do you wish to actually hunt now?” Catra hesitated.

“Wait. Melog. I have to ask. What was it like, in the prison? Did they treat you well?”

“It was… uncomfortable. Glimmer visited me once and was kind to me, and ensured that I had the sustenance I required. She apologized, but said that she couldn’t risk you finding me. Most of the other prisoners treated me kindly. It wasn’t so bad.” Catra growled, her fur puffing up.

“That fucker. But now I do have you. I can’t believe she locked you away. It’s disgusting. I hate her.”

“I do not. She did not have evil intentions. I do not forgive her, but I do not hate her either.”

“That doesn’t mean she’s not evil.”

“Hmm. Perhaps. How have you been with me away?”

“I’ve managed. It’s really great to have you back. And I now have been chosen to be the godmother to this baby Kyle and Rogelio found. Kyle and Rogelio are my friends from the Horde. Also Spinerella and Netossa are having a baby, and Spinerella is pregnant. And they adopted Frosta. And Glimmer killed Hordak. And the princesses aren’t really princesses anymore? Also, I started talking to Perfuma about… stuff. And Perfuma and Scorpia are together now, and Rogelio and Kyle? And me and Adora are on separate sides of the battlefield, so, not too much happened.”

“That is… very much that happened. I’m not sure what questions to ask first.”

“I’ll explain it on the way back. It’s a lot, I know. Anyway, you want to hunt? I’m thinking… maybe one of those dumb tree-rats.”

“Squirrels are not tree-rats.”

“Close enough!”

“Not close enough actually, they are very different biologically. But anyway, yes, I do wish to hunt.”

“Great. Try not to hinder me too much, buddy.”

“I highly doubt that I will hinder you.” Catra glared at Melog.

“...I’m going to choose not to take that personally.”

“Hey, Adora!” Catra called out as she saw Adora on the edge of her vision. They ran towards each other and embraced. A warm feeling grew in Catra’s heart.

“Catra! It’s so good to see you. Are you okay? Please be okay. I heard about you getting Melog back, and I’m so glad!” Adora replied.

“Yeah, it’s been a relief. And now we can both run away to the rebellion together! Finally!” Catra exclaimed. Adora pulled away.

“What? No! I can’t leave Glimmer!” Adora protested. Catra’s heart stopped, and her head began to spin.

“She imprisoned MELOG. You have to leave!”

“I know, and that’s a totally valid point, but you don’t understand. Glimmer is sick. Really sick. I can’t abandon her! But I can fix this! I’ve been researching carefully how to cure it, and I finally realized how to cure it!”

“No, Adora! You can’t fix everything! She’s a bad person! Sometimes, you just have to leave people!” Catra gritted her teeth as Adora opened her mouth.

“I didn’t leave you! I stuck by with you, even after you had done all those horrible things, because I knew you were trying!” Sadness began to build in Catra’s heart, getting bigger and stronger, becoming a tsunamai,

“You did leave me! You abandoned me in the horde!”

“You could have come with me!”

“You still left me! Why did you leave for me, but didn’t leave for her?” The tsunamai finally crashed, shattering everything.

“I’m-I’m sorry Catra, but-”

“No. You don’t have to be sorry. It’s not your fault. It just still hurts.”

“I understand, Catra. And I am sorry.” Catra and Adora embraced again, and Catra slipped away into Adora’s embrace, and cried, clinging onto Adora. Her tears dried, and she lost herself in Adora’s embrace for a few moments.

“I love you, Adora.”

“I love you too, Catra.”

Catra slunk back into the village just as the sky began to lighten. The village lay on the edge of waking up and starting their day. Village could come out at any second and see Catra. A few

sentries made circles, their eyes slowly roving over their surroundings, most of them sleeping or talking amongst themselves. Catra snuck past them, sticking to the shadows where they didn't bother looking, careful not to make a sound.

As she reached the cluster of houses where she lived, her fur started to lie back down. Maybe I could say I was just out walking! Catra thought. But in the middle of the night? Would they even believe me?

Suddenly, the door to Netossa and Spinerella's house flung open, and Catra jumped back to a hiding place, her fur puffed up and her claws out. Spinerella stumbled out, and vomited into a nearby trash can. Wow, pregnancy looks like the worst, Catra thought as she let out a breath.

"What are you doing up so early, wildcat?" Scorpia loudly asked from behind her, Catra yelped and spun around.

"Scorpia! You scared me!" Catra hissed.

"Sorry, sorry!" Scorpia apologized, waving her pincers around. "But wait, what are you doing here?"

"I'm… going for a walk! What are you doing is a better question?" Catra asked, turning the question back around on Scorpia. You're such an idiot Catra. She is obviously doing something important, Catra thought.

"I'm going for my daily morning walk, duh! But I thought you hated mornings and getting up early? Why are you up?" As Catra opened her mouth, guilt began to coat her thoughts. I've done enough to Scorpia. Can I really just lie to her? I thought I'd changed! Catra thought. She groaned. Ugh, I just KNOW I'm going to regret this.

"Okay, I'll tell you, but you have to PROMISE not to tell anyone. Got it?" Scorpia nodded. "I may have… been meeting up with

Adora. Maybe.” Scorpia gasped, and covered her mouth with her pincers.

“WHAT?!”

“Sssh! Not so loud!”

“Sorry, sorry! Have you told her any of your rebellion secrets?”

“Scorpia. We don’t HAVE rebellion secrets. And no, I have not told her anything very important. ...Recently, at least. I just have to spend time with her, you know? What if someone separated you and Perfuma?” Scorpia blushed and looked away.

“I don’t know what I would do then… I really care about her.”

“Yeah. Please, don’t tell anyone!” Scorpia hesitated for a moment as Catra waited, her stomach churning.

“Can I tell me and Perfuma’s plants?”

“You and Perfuma’s plants…?”

“I love our plants. I know they can’t respond or understand anything, but I always tell them everything. It makes me feel better.”

“...Yes. You can tell your plants, Scorpia. Tell all the plants you want.” Scorpia grinned, and suddenly, a weight slid off of Catra’s chest.

“Thank you so much, Catra! You won’t regret telling me, I promise!” Scorpia smiled and walked away, continuing on with her walk.

“I highly doubt that information,” Catra muttered, but she couldn’t help but smile as Scorpia walked off. What if the rest of the council finds out? What if they kick me out? What if I won’t be able to see Adora again? Catra worried. At least I didn’t lie to Scorpia. At least there’s that.

“Okay, Adora, you can do this,” Adora remarked to herself. “I can totally do this. All that time studying how to destroy things will pay off!”

Adora’s stomach churned as she stared at the First Ones ruin ahead of her. Her trying to destroy things had backfired before. Who knew that it wouldn’t backfire now?

She walked into the temple, striding forward with her head up. Fake it till you make it. There was no way this could go wrong. Yep. No way. But as Adora strode into the ruin, her stomach only began to churn harder.

Data crystals lined the walls, and shone against the few intact lights. Bright and jagged crystal made up the bruised and battered walls, few still uncracked. Adora stumbled over bits of broken floor as she walked. Why can’t She-ra just give me perfect balance? Adora wondered as she narrowly avoided crashing to the floor yet again.

As she neared the center, her skin began to prickle, the little hairs on her skin standing up. Her eyes began to dart side to side. If Catra was here she’d probably call me a paranoid idiot and then jump into my arms at the slightest noise. Then deny the whole thing, Adora thought, chuckling.

As Adora turned the corner, the end of the passageway lay before her, in a circular room with several other archways, and a glowing

red crystal up on a pedestal in the middle. Adora shuddered at the sight, and inched closer, her eyes darting from side to side.

"Fuck. Okay, I can do this. I can do this. Concentrate, Adora, you idiot. Concentrate…" Adora urged herself as she aimed at the sword at the glowing green crystal. She-ra's power began to swirl around in her, bright and overpowering. She yelled, sending power through the sword to the glowing green crystal. It shot out of her body, leaving her stumbling, and absorbed into the glowing green crystal. A moment of silence. Then nothing. "Huh?"

Adora walked closer, inspecting the crystal. It still glowed green. Interesting. She tapped on it once, focusing her eyes on the crystal. Then, she saw the glow of the crystal starting to expand.

"Fuck," She said, just as the crystal exploded, and blew her backwards, send her flying into the nearest wall. Her eyes rolled back into her head, and she faded into the darkness.

Adora noticed the throbbing pain in her head first when she came to. It pierced through her head, and aching and stabbing pain all at once. Adora groaned and struggled up, rubbing her head. Big mistake. The pain multiplied all at once, and she yelped.

"Fuuuuuck," She swore, looking around. At least that blast HAD to have destroyed that stupid, fucking green cystal. Fucker. Adora got up, and headed past the rubble to the altar where she'd see the green crystal surely had to have been destroyed

Except, there it lay, fully intact and still glowing. What the fuck? How could it have survived the blast? Adora groaned and yelled very obscene, specific insults at it. After all that studying, after all

that preparation, she had nothing to show for it but a she-ra damned headache.

What kind of friend am I? Adora wondered. I can't even help my sick friend as She-ra! How could I fail Glimmer like this? Adora drew in a breath, and let it out. I can't fix everything. And I can't expect to fix everything on the first try. I'll find a way to fix this. I have to.

Adora walked out of the temple, her shoulders squared and her chin held high. I will fix this. I will.

"Alright, next section of the council meeting! Integrating Frosta into the rebellion. First motion: should we add her to the council, or give her a different role? Or, perhaps, she could enroll in school, given that she's turning fifteen soon?" Catra asked.

"I've been ruling a kingdom since I was a kid. I can handle responsibility. And I'm not going back to school," Frosta replied.

"Frosta, sweetheart, you're still a kid. And you're not ruling a kingdom anymore," Spinerella responded.

"UGH. I've ruled a kingdom before! I should get to choose whether I go back to school or not!" Frosta complained.

"Young lady. Like it or not, we're your guardians. You have to listen to us. Why do you hate going back to school so much?" Spinerella asked. Frosta rolled her eyes. Oh, great, Catra thought. Another family fight for the ages.

“Darling, let me handle this. Frosta, you’re going to need to learn if you want to step up into a leadership role someday. We need you to learn, and improve your skills. And if you go to school part-time and start learning, I think I’d trust you enough to help me track down criminals in the crimson wastes. How does that sound?” Netossa asked.

“Netossa! She’s fourteen!” Spinerella objected.

“And she’s fought in a war the last few years! I’m sure she can handle it. And besides, there’ll be someone else there to watch her- I mean assist her! Plus, blowing things up and imprisoning outlaws builds character! What do you think, Frosta?” Netossa queried.

“That sounds ama- I mean it’s fine, I guess. It’s cool. But I better not be learning boring stuff in school!” Frosta ordered. Netossa and Spinerella exchanged a look, smiling.

“I’ll make sure your teacher teaches you interesting topics, dear,” Spinerella assured her, rolling her eyes and smiling. Ugh, do they have to be such a cheesy, perfect family? Can’t they see it’s getting on everyone’s nerves? Catra thought.

“AHEM. If that’s over with, can we move onto the next order of business?” Catra asked, clearing her throat. She waited a split second. “Great, now that THAT is over with, let’s move onto the next order of business! Should we declare war on the princess alliance?”

“Aren’t we already at war? I mean, we’ve attacked some of their settlements, and literally raided their castle,” Lonne pointed out. Catra breathed out sharply.

“OKAY, first of all, they weren’t their settlements, exactly. They were on the princesses land!” Catra objected.

“But didn’t we strip them of their royalty and royal powers and rulerships over their kingdoms?” Lonnie asked.

“Well, yes, but… but it was still their land originally! And it's not like the princess alliance had any more stake than us! Plus, the villagers liked us! Anyway, we need to make it official. I want this rebellion to be cool and official, not like the original princess alliance,” Catra replied.

“Hey! I was part of that princess alliance, and I can assure you that we were very cool and official!” Perfuma complained, frowning.

“If you have to say that you were cool, you weren’t cool,” Catra said. Lonnie snorted, and Huntara’s mouth twitched. “No, let’s continue-”

“Hey! My girlfriend is cool!” Scorpia defended Perfuma, taking Perfuma’s hand and blushing.

“Thank you, Scorpia. You’re so sweet! See? I’m cool, Catra!” Perfuma said. Catra rubbed her brow and sighed. How did this devolve into a discussion over whether Perfuma is cool? Catra wondered.

“Okay, fine, you’re cool, Perfuma. Whatever. Now can we PLEASE talk about the actual proposal? Of whether to officially declare war or not?” Catra questioned.

“I don’t know. It seems like a bunch of cushy princess stuff. Why do we need to make it official? Doesn’t seem to make a difference,” Huntara remarked, crossing her arms.

“It’s not cushy princess stuff! It makes us seem official! Like we’re posing a real threat! This way we’ll go down in history as a legitimate rebellion!” Catra said.

“Why can’t we just go down in history for actually rebelling? Like smashing the enemy’s stuff! We don’t do enough of that!” Frosta complained. Catra rubbed her head, and tried not to bang her head on the table.

“We can, I just want to make it official! Entrapta, you haven’t really contributed anything so far. What do you think?” Catra asked.

“Hmmm. I’ve been cataloguing your social interactions for my data, but I have been considering the problem. The data seems to suggest that an official declaration of war would make us seem more official with minimal effort and risk,” Entrapta responded.

“See? Entrapta agrees with me! And she’s the science person! She would know!” Catra exclaimed.

“I suppose I don’t really care as long as I keep getting to fight. I don’t want to have to start doing any cushy diplomacy or tactical retreats,” Huntara declared.

“I second that. Is that what you’re supposed to say, darling? I’m not quite sure,” Spinerella remarked.

“Great! Any objections?” Catra asked. She waited a few moments, and no-one came forward. “Great, now let’s start drafting!”

“Can we add stuff about smashing? I want to smash things!” Frosta said, bouncing up and down.

“And how we’ll totally win the war, because we’re the best and the coolest?” Netossa added on. Catra rolled her eyes.

“...Yes. We can add in stuff about that,” Catra conceded. “How are we going to get it to them, though?”

“I can get it to an outpost at the border,” Spinerella volunteered.

“Thank you, Spinerella! You know, sometimes you guys are pretty okay,” Catra admitted.

“We’re sometimes pretty okay?” Perfuma questioned, raising an eyebrow. Catra huffed.

“Okay, you all are pretty okay usually,” Catra said. Perfuma rolled her eyes, but she smiled.

“Thanks, I guess,” Perfuma replied.

Catra woke up, sweating, from a nightmare. Something about her failing to defeat a bunch of giant mice seeking revenge.
She turned back into bed and closed her eyes, but sleep refused to come. Eventually, she got up, and let out a growl.

“Stupid fucking nightmares,” Catra muttered as she got out of bed. She left her house and hopped onto the roof. The moons cast light and shadows all around the sleeping town.

Spinerella, Netossa, and Frosta’s house lay a few meters away, with no lights on inside, and a small, tidy, disgustingly cozy garden out front. Perfuma and Scorpia’s house stood two streets over, with a huge, unruly garden and tons and tons of flowers, with a few cacti hanging around. They had replaced their door with a mat woven of plants hanging in the door frame after Scorpia had accidentally crushed the door handle a few times too many.

Huntara’s house lay near the town square, with sand and cacti in the front yard(Grown courtesy of Perfuma), along with a well used punching bag. Entrapta’s house lay next to it, devoid of plant life besides a few really weird plants Entrapta grew for her ‘experiments’.

Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle's house took up the most space by far, with three bedrooms for Lonnie, Garnet, and Rogelio and Kyle. A few spare tech scraps lay in the yard from Rogelio's (mostly)failed attempts to create modern baby equipment. Idiots, all of them. Though Lonnie could be classified as less of an idiot. Catra chuckled, and began to purr as she looked over all of her friend's houses.

If only Adora were here, Catra thought. She would try to organize everything with some crazy schedule and rules, and she would drive everyone crazy but they'd still love her. Tears began to gather in Catra's eyes and she curled up into a ball. As the tears dropped, Catra rocked herself back and forth.

Just a few days until I see her again… just a few days… Catra reminded herself. Catra's heart swelled as she stared up at the moons, and her tears began to fall faster. Maybe Adora is looking up at the moons right now. Maybe she's thinking about me right now.

Adora… if you're out there, I need you. Please.

Adora woke to the moons casting their rays over her. Their glow softened the harsh shadows of the night. Adora crept from her bed, sliding on her new clothes.

The high ceilings of the Brightmoon hallways loomed over Adora, and she stuck to the shadows. Adora passed by Mermista's quarters, donned with seashells and coral, and the newly improved Brightmoon library, run by Bow's dads.

Her eyes ran over the Brightmoon garden, with its flowers dull since Perfuma's departure. And patches of dirt lay where once

Frosta's ice sculptures once stood. Adora looked away and kept moving.

Adora climbed the twisting and narrow stairs up to Brightmoon's roof. Catra used to come here all the time after the battle for Etheria, Adora thought, smiling.

The whirling thoughts in Adora's mind began to settle once she reached the roof and looked up at the moons. The moons shone, and complemented the stars perfectly. All those people who never got to see the stars… How could you live without them? Adora wondered.

If Catra were here, she'd tease me about my new outfit, but love how soft it is when we cuddled. And then she'd nip down the the kitchen and steal something for us to snack on, Adora thought, a faint smile on her lips.

If only she were here, Adora thought, gazing up at the night sky, suddenly aware of the coldness of the night air beside her. If only she were here.

"Look, I'm just saying, maybe there's a godamn reason why me, Adora, and you are the only princesses left in the princess alliance," Mermista said, glaring at Glimmer over the council table.

"And maybe that reason is that they were disloyal! I need people who won't abandon me when things get a tiny bit fucking harder than usual!" Glimmer replied.

“Come on guys, we’re still the princess alliance!” Bow encouraged, smiling. Adora slumped in her chair, fiddling with the edge of her sleeve.

“UUUGGGHHH! Bow, I know you’re just trying to help, but please, stay out of this. But having half of our friends abandon us and then having you drive everyone else away isn’t exactly a tiny bit fucking harder!” Mermista responded. Adora squeezed her eyes shut. Here it comes, She thought.

“They abandoned us! How dare-” Glimmer said.

“STOP! Just STOP. I’m tired of you two fighting. Please, just take a break from each other for a little while,” Adora asked. A moment of silence passed.

“Whatever. I have better things to do with my time,” Mermist said, tossing her hair and stalking out of the room.

“And I have better things to do with my time!” Glimmer exclaimed.

“Glimmer, just stop. I’m tired of this,” Adora sighed.

“Well maybe this wouldn’t be happening if you had found a way to heal me already!” Glimmer argued. Adora flinched.

“I’m trying my best, Glimmer! And you can’t blame everything on whatever is infecting you! You have to take some control! You have to take some responsibility! If you did, maybe things could get better!” Adora pressed.

“Shut up,” Glimmer hissed.

“Well, OKAY then. It seems that we might be having a bit of a rough patch… why don’t we revisit this tomorrow?” Bow asked.

“Fine. But don’t expect me to change my stance,” Glimmer said, walking out of the room.

“Maybe things will be better tomorrow?” Adora asked.

“Yeah, maybe… are you okay?” Bow asked.

“Not really. I can’t believe I haven’t cured Glimmer yet! Why haven’t I? I’m such a failure of a She-ra. I can’t even defeat a First Ones virus!” Adora complained.

“Hey. Don’t talk like that. You’ll figure out how to fix it, I just bet! If you just keep your head up, and think positively, you’ll be fine!” Bow encouraged, smiling. Adora smiled back.

“Thanks, Bow,” Adora said before leaving. Maybe things will be alright, Adora thought. But how can they ever be again, with everything that’s happened?

The Final Confrontation

Chapter Summary

> As tensions grow, it seems that a battle is inevitable. While Glimmer and Adora fight over the princess alliance, Catra struggles to be a leader to her people, and how to deal with the princess alliance. And when a figure from the past arrives, Catra begins to slip. Will Catra and Adora's relationship survive? Will anything surive?

Chapter Notes

> As you can see, I'm finally getting better at writing Chapter summaries. Yay, me! I worked hard on this chapter, so I hope you enjoy it.

“Does the princesses alliance pose any real threat anymore?” Scorpia asked. “I mean, it’s just Salineas, Mystacor, and Brightmoon at this point.”

“Plenty of threat,” Catra replied. “They could attack us at any moment. We need to be vigilant. They still pose a threat, and people could still get hurt.”

“You mean because of She-” Frosta started. Catra cut her off with a glare.

“Don’t say it. And who the hell let you in here, anyway?” Catra asked.

“We did. We thought it would be good for Frosta to observe the council meetings in real time,” Spinerella answered, gesturing to her and Netossa. “Can she stay?” Catra rolled her eyes.

“I don’t care enough to kick her out. Just please don’t say anything,” Catra said. “Now can we please continue on with the meeting? Yes? Good. I suggest we set up watches along the

border to make sure no invading armies come in. All refugees welcome though, of course."

"I don't know. Surely our resources could be put to better use than for war?" Perfuma asked.

"It's not war, Flower Girl. It's just defense so that if they DO attack, we can defend ourselves," Huntara replied.

"I know, but I just think our resources could be put to better use. What about an improved agricultural system?" Perfuma suggested. Catra rolled her eyes and opened her mouth to speak.

"Perfuma, I know you really hate conflict and violence, but please consider it. It wouldn't even mean any fighting! If anything, it would just mean that if we were attacked, villagers would be able to flee in advance. It would mean less deaths, even!" Scorpia said.

"I'm just not sure about this. I don't like the idea of having to prepare for battle. It makes it feel inevitable, and I don't like that," Perfuma admitted. Catra's train of thought stopped right there. Fuck. A battle means battling the princess alliance… the WHOLE princess alliance. I would have to fight Adora, Catra thought.

"And I understand that. But we have to protect the villagers, and ourselves," Scorpia replied. Perfuma nodded. They both looked to Catra, who snapped out of her trance.

"Okay, so do we have unanimous approval?" Catra asked.

"Yes. You do," Perfuma answered.

"Great. Let's move on?" Catra asked. Everyone nodded. They continued to the next topic of conversation, but Catra's mind lingered. What if I have to be the one to go up against She-ra? What if I have to be the one to fight Adora? How could I ever do that again? And how could I ever live with myself if I did?

“Hey, Mermista! Good to see you! Glimmer sent me here to help rebuild Salineas… anything I can help you with?” Adora asked, shifting from foot to foot. Mermista lay hunched over her royal throne.

“Just… go help with some lifting. I need to go eat ice cream in my bathtub and cry,” Mermista replied, not looking Adora in the eyes.

“Um… are you okay?” Adora questioned, moving a little closer. Adora winced. Of course she’s not fucking okay, you idiot! Adora thought.

“Ugghhhh. You want me to list out my problems? Do you really want me to list out aaaallll of them? Fine, I will. First of all, Seahawk lit ANOTHER boat on fire, so I’ve got to deal with that. And a bunch of my citizens are really angry at me because the rebuilding is taking too long. And finally, Glimmer won’t let me anyone even slightly affiliated with the rebellion trade with Salineas or help us rebuild, even though it would speed up the rebuilding process by a LOT. And we got into suuuuuch a long argument over it. I’m done. I’m just fucking done,” Mermista declared, sinking back into her chair.

“Wait, Glimmer did what?” Adora asked.

“I knoooow, it’s such a dick move,” Mermista complained. Adora rubbed her temples.

“I’ll talk to her. Because I have to talk to her about everything now. I swear, I have to keep her in check on every. Little. Thing,” Adora hissed. “Sorry. I’m fine. Completely fucking fine.”

“Damn. Sounds like you need to eat ice cream in a tub too,” Mermista commented.

“What? No! I don’t need to do that! It’s fine! It’s all fine, and I’m handling it all like a champ… definitely...” Adora trailed off. Mermista rolled her eyes.

“Adora. You need to take some time off. I know stuff like helping people and exercise and… lifting shit helps you for some reason, but just take the afternoon off. And don’t use it to exercise or fix some problem or help somebody. Just take off an afternoon, for once in your godamn life,” Mermista said.

“What? I can’t do that! I’m She-ra! I have responsibilities! I have things I have to do, places I need to go, people I need to help…” Adora replied.

“Fuuuuck, I totally forgot how uptight and annoying you were. JUST TAKE AN AFTERNOON OFF. IT’S NOT THAT FUCKING HARD, ADORA,” Mermista ordered.

“I don’t know… what would I even do?” Adora asked.

“How the fuck am I supposed to know? Take a walk, or a bubble bath! Make a pillow fort in your room and eat half a cake. See the remaining and rebuilt sights of Salineas. Go to a restaurant. Talk to someone who you’re not trying to help as She-ra. Just do SOMETHING to relax!” Mermista said. Adora hesitated. The idea of taking a walk or going out to eat made her shoulders and teeth unclench… but surely she had some responsibilities to do, right? But the idea of taking time of was just so tempting...

“Okay. But I’m spending the morning helping to rebuild Salineas!” Adora said, walking out of the throne room

“Fine. And when you go back to Brightmoon, don’t be a pushover for Glimmer!” Mermista yelled as Adora left the throne room.

As Adora strolled along the beach, Mermista's words echoed in her mind. Don't be a pushover for Glimmer! Take an afternoon off for yourself! The words bounced around in her head, over and over.

But I'm not a pushover for Glimmer, right? I stood up for myself, and made her take some responsibility. That's not being a pushover, right? Adora thought. Adora kicked a nearby rock into the ocean, hard.

The rock plopped into the bright and choppy waves of the ocean. The ocean stretched out before Adora, endless and energetic. Adora looked out at the ocean longingly. The cold and salty waves would feel so good on Adora's skin…

Adora slipped off her boots and waded into the water, letting the waves wash over her toes. Adora let out a sigh, and finally stopped clenching her teeth. Glancing both ways, Adora slipped off the rest of her clothes, and slid into the water completely.

Her weights and burdens slid off of her as she floated on the waves, letting them rise and fall. Adora let her eyes close, and the shifting waves carry her. The waves went up and down and up and down and up and down… over and over and over again.

After a few minutes, Adora swam back to shore, shook herself dry, and slipped back into her clothes. Adora kept her eyes on the setting sun as she took the winding walk back to Salineas. No matter what happens at least I know the sun will always set, Adora thought. At least I can always count on that.

Catra tried her best not to growl as yet ANOTHER villager brought up an unimportant claim.

“But there’s a nationwide beet shortage! How am I supposed to make my famous beet stew?” The villager complained.

“How do I say this politely? The national beet shortage is NOT a pressing issue. Now GO HOME,” Catra ordered, collapsing in her chair as the villager stormed out. “This next petitioner had BETTER have an actual issue.” Catra looked up and her jaw nearly dropped. Double Trouble’s voice entered her ears.

“Don’t worry, darling. I have some VERY important information that I have no doubt you’ll be wanting,” Double Trouble hinted, tossing their hair.

“What are you doing here?” Catra demanded, her fur standing on end. Double Trouble chuckled.

“Ouch. It seems I’m a touchy subject, kitten,” Double Trouble replied.

“Don’t call me kitten,” Catra growled.

“Why are you here? Last time I heard, you betrayed Catra… ohhhh,” Scorpia said, looking between Double Trouble and Catra.

“Oh, right, sorry for betraying you. But that’s all in the past now. And I have some VERY interesting news for you now,” Double Trouble teased. Catra dug her claws into the table.

“Is this some sort of sick joke? We’re not giving you a single cent of our money. I’ll drag that information out of you if I-” Catra stopped for a moment and took a deep breath as Melog nudged her. “You’re going to tell us the information. Now.”

“Actually, I’d rather not. My services come do at a price,” Double Trouble replied, studying their nails.

“What is your price?” Spinerella asked.

“Hmm… well I’ll be needing my own residence in town, well furnished, of course. Amnesty and protection if I ever need it, and….” They trailed off.

“And?” Perfuma prompted.

“And I want a seat on this council, to represent the arts,” Double Trouble declared. Catra shot up, and let out a laugh.

“No way in the horde am I letting you on this council,” Catra snarled.

“Then you’ll never know what I know. In that case, I suppose I’ll leave now. Petition resolved, it seems,” Double Trouble replied, taking a bow and beginning to leave.

“Wait! Catra, we could use Double Trouble’s information, you know that. And it’s not like we have anything going on in the arts. Please, just let Double Trouble take the council position,” Lonnie urged Catra.

“They betrayed me!” Catra responded. “How can you even think about letting Double Trouble on the council?” The other council members shifted in their seats.

“Because, Cat Girl, we need this information. We have no idea what it’s about. And they would just be the councilmember on the arts, nothing more. And you were with the horde when Double Trouble betrayed you,” Huntara said, crossing her arms.

“That doesn’t change the fact that they betrayed me! Don’t any of you know how it feels to be betrayed?” Catra asked.

“I’m sorry, Catra. We might need this information. Please, Catra, let’s hear them out,” Perfuma pleaded. Catra sat down, and closed

her eyes for a moment.

“Fine,” Catra agreed. Double Trouble grinned.

“Good choice, kitten. I happen to know for certain that Glimmer is planning a direct attack on this town right here just a few days from now. The day after tomorrow at sunset, to be exact. Just thought you might want to know,” Double Trouble replied.

“WHAT?!” Catra yelled getting out of her chair Catra’s head spun, and her stomach churned. She clenched her fists. “Are you serious?”

“Absolutely. Oh, and by the way, my sources are me. I heard it myself, right from the mouth of Queen Glimmer. I posed as her guard for a while,” Double Trouble continued.

“We aren’t prepared for an attack! We have to raise an army, prepare defenses, gather supplies… how on Etheria can we prepare in three days?” Perfuma asked, fiddling with her hair.

“I can help with that, as your newest councilmember, of course. I can get you a better battle plan to help you prepare. And in the meantime, I recommend you use your powers to secure this town. And if I were you? I’d evacuate the villagers, darlings. Glimmer doesn’t seem like she’s in much of a merciful mood,” Double Trouble said.

“If you’re lying… you’ll pay for it,” Catra warned.

“We’ve got the means to back up that threat, by the way,” Netossa added, clutching one of her nets. Double Trouble only smiled wider.

“Calm down, kitten. I wouldn’t lie about this. I can tell you on my honor, I’m not lying,” Double Trouble assured them.

“Maybe. But your honor doesn’t exactly mean much, at least from what I’ve heard,” Huntara said.

“True. But why would I lie?” Double Trouble questioned. “So do you trust me?” Double Trouble’s gaze traveled over the councilmembers, lingering on each one for a few moments.

“I trust you,” Perfuma said.

“I trust you too,” Scorpia added. The other councillors began to echo their agreements, and Catra sank lower into her seat.

“Well, kitten? Do you trust me?” Double Trouble asked, cocking their head. Catra growled.

“I don’t trust you. But… I’m outvoted anyway. Do what you want, and report back to us,” Catra ordered. Double Trouble smiled, and Catra clenched her fists. Double Trouble had better be right about this, Catra thought.

“Adora!” Catra called out as she spotted Adora entering the clearing. She bounded over and threw herself into Adora’s arms. A gentle purr rose in her chest.

“Catra! It’s nice to see you too, I guess,” Adora joked. Catra rolled her eyes, then leaned in for a kiss. A fire lit in Catra as Adora leaned into her kiss. They pulled apart after a moment, both blushing in the early morning light.

“There’s something I need to tell you, Adora,” Catra said, swallowing hard. ‘Glimmer is planning to attack our village tomorrow at sunset. Please, I know you’ve refused to leave in the

past, but don’t leave me alone for this.” Adora stepped back, her mouth opening and closing a few times.

“Glimmer… Glimmer wouldn’t do that! I have to talk to her, see what’s actually going on. And how do you know this, anyway?” Adora accused. Catra growled.

“Excuse me?” She replied. “What are you implying?”

“Are you spying on us?” Adora asked.

“No! Double Trouble sold us the information. We didn’t go out and spy on you.” Catra avoided Adora’s eyes.

“Oh, and that’s SO much better.” Catra’s gaze snapped back up.

“YOU’RE the ones attacking us! A peaceful village! We’re not harming anyone! You’re the ones in the wrong, DUH!”

“But how can you trust Double Trouble? They betrayed us both!”

“I don’t trust Double Trouble. I just don’t think they have any reason to lie about this. And you have to leave with me!”

“No! I could convince Glimmer to call off the battle! I can fix things!”

“You can’t fix everything, Adora! Just be selfish, for once!”

“Why can’t you let me just TRY? You’re acting like Shadow Weaver! You’re always trying to manipulate and control me! You never let me choose things on my own!” Catra stopped, her world frozen. Her eyes began to fill with tears, and her blood turned to molten lava.

“Yeah? Well, last time I checked, these were our part of the whispering woods. So if I see you again, I won’t hesitate to bring you in.” Adora stepped back.

“Wait, Catra, I’m sorry, I went too-” Catra cut Adora off with a growl.

“What did you not understand about LEAVE? Just LEAVE ME ALONE, Adora. Just abandon me, since apparently you’re SO good at it!” Tears streamed down Catra’s cheeks, and Adora’s eyes widened before she turned and left, sobbing.

Catra fell to the ground, her legs to longer supporting her. She rocked back and forth, tears flowing down her cheeks.

“Adora…” She whispered. Why can’t things be okay, for ONCE? Why can’t I have a happy ending? Why can’t I deserve one?

Adora pushed open the doors of Glimmer’s Brightmoon suite, to find Glimmer reading a book. Glimmer raised an eyebrow, glancing over the top of her book.

“What is it, Adora?” Glimmer asked.

“Please tell me it isn’t true. Just- please,” Adora begged, her hair falling into her face. Adora didn’t bother brushing it back.

“Tell you what isn’t true? You’ll have to be more specific, Adora,” Glimmer replied. A mad hope that Double Trouble had been lying rose. Maybe Double Trouble had been lying for attention? Adora sucked in a breath.

“I heard…” Adora trailed off, gathering some strength. “...that you ordered an attack on the rebellion headquarters. Please tell me

the truth.” Glimmer hesitated, and if Adora had a seat, she’d be sitting on the edge of it.

“...I did order an attack on the rebellion headquarters. But I won’t be lectured from you about it. I was going to tell you as soon as you got back. And you want to know the reason I did it? I did it because your precious Catra is planning an attack! Their spies have been lurking all around our border! They’re obviously planning an attack! We have to strike first.”

“No, Glimmer, they’re not! They’re probably just making sure you’re not going to invade! Please, call off the attack, Glimmer!”

“No! The rebellion is a threat to all of us! I have to protect Brightmoon.” Adora slumped into a nearby chair, everything weighing down on her.

“Glimmer, no. If you do attack them on their turf, where their people outnumber yours- not to mention that they have more princesses- you’ll be slaughtered. You have to call it off!” Adora got out of her chair as she made that last remark.

“Not with She-ra! With you, we can win this battle! We can win this war. We’ll be unstoppable! We’ll have everything we ever wanted!”

“No, we won’t! Because we’ll have lost all of our friends along the way! And because I’M NOT FIGHTING FOR YOU.” Glimmer stepped back, her eyes narrowing.

“Excuse me?”

“I can’t fight against my friends. I just can’t. And how could you tell me the day before the battle? The battle is literally tomorrow at sunset!”

“Tomorrow at sunset? What? The battle is tonight at sunset! I lied about the date to Double Trouble after I realized who they were!

Wait. ARE YOU IN CONTACT WITH THE REBELLION?” Adora flinched.

“It’s not like that, Glimmer! I just met up with Catra, because-”

“You met up with CATRA? The godsdamned LEADER OF THE REBELLION?!” Adora stepped forward.

“I never sold us out, or betrayed you! And that’s a LOT, given how you’ve treated me. You’ve treated me horribly, Glimmer. I’m leaving.” Adora turned and began to stalk out, tears gathering in her eyes.

“No traitor is going to leave Brightmoon with classified information. Ever. Guards! Seize Adora!” Adora whirled around.

“Glimmer! You can’t be serious! I’m not a traitor!” Adora moved to Glimmer, but Glimmer’s fists alit with her magic. Guards burst into the room.

Adora stepped back, hesitating. The guards looked between Glimmer and Adora.

“Please, Glimmer.” Glimmer hesitated for a moment. But then her gaze turned to steel.

“What are you waiting for? Arrest her!” The guards charged towards Adora, who dodged. Adora raised her hand over her head, and let She-ra’s magic flow through her.

“For the honor OF GRAYSKULL!” Adora became She-ra, and raised her sword overhead, then brought it to the floor. A wave of light rushed out of it, blinding Glimmer and the guards. Adora took a quick look around, but then smashed the window, and slid down the walls of Brightmoon.

She ran to the edge of the Whispering woods, letting the trees cover her. The sound of guards running and yelling filled her ears. She took one last glance at Brightmoon where Glimmer oversaw all of the guards, teleporting around with gusto. Tears built in

Adora’s eyes, but she wiped them away, letting the trees of the whispering woods surround her.

“Move the weapon crates over there!” Catra ordered, pacing around with a clipboard. All the yelling and orders brought back memories of the Fright Zone, and it made Catra’s skin prickle. “But don’t freak out if you break anything or mess up!”

“Excuse me, Catra, do you have a moment?” Perfuma asked, coming up from behind her. Catra turned around.

“I guess. What is it?” Catra asked.

“We’re not quite sure on when to evacuate the villagers. What do you think?” Perfuma responded. Catra stopped for a moment.

“We can’t let the princess alliance know that we’re preparing for their attack. Evacuate them this evening, after sunset, so they can move under the cover of darkness.”

“Thanks. Have a good day, I suppose.” Perfuma smiled and walked off, leaving Catra with a creeping sensation that she couldn’t quite shake off.

Adora stumbled through the forest for the millionth time. Had she passed that tree already? It looked strangely familiar. Her head hadn't stopped spinning from her conversation with Glimmer, and the trees seemed to be guiding her in a circle.

"Argh. Am I seriously lost AGAIN? I have some people to save!" Adora called out into the forest.

"When you're lost in the whispering woods, there's usually a reason. Or at least that's what I've seen from you, Dearie," Madame Razz said from behind Adora. Adora whirled around to see Madame Razz smiling at her, holding a broom.

"Madame Razz! Please, I really need your help. I'm lost, and while I appreciate whatever 'lesson' the whispering woods is trying to teach me right now, I really need to get somewhere!" Adora replied. Madame Razz looked Adora in the eyes for a moment, then relaxed and smiled.

"Hmmm. That sounds like quite the conundrum, dearie!" Madame Razz remarked. Adora groaned and rolled her eyes.

"Could you maybe help me? Please?"

"Madame Razz doesn't know where you are! How am I supposed to help you, hmmm, dearie? Maybe the woods are trying to teach you something!"

"Look, Razz, I like you, but I really don't have time for this. I have to help my friends." Madame Razz adjusted her glasses.

"Oh, Mara, dearie, you were always so silly. Maybe there's another way to help your friends, you silly goose!" Adora sighed.

"Razz. I'm not Mara, I'm Adora. ADORA."

"I don't have my glasses dearie. You'll have to speak up."

"Your glasses are right on your face, Razz. And that's not how that works." Madame Razz tapped on her glasses, her face lighting up.

“They are? I had no idea! Sorry, dearie, I’ve been rather confused lately. Something’s been wrong with the ground. I think Loo-Kee has been messing with my plants!”

“Loo-Kee?”

“My friend, Loo-Kee! He’s a trickster, so you can never see him. I think he’s been infecting the soil. I pull out the bad plants, but it’s the soil!”

“I don’t- wait. The plants aren’t the problem!” It hit Adora so suddenly, she could barely believe it. Of COURSE. It made sense.

“Yes, dearie. I just said that.”

“I have to go, Razz, I have something to do!”

“Aren’t you lost?”

“I don’t think I will be anymore! Thanks, Razz!” Adora dashed off, leaving Razz behind her. Finally. Maybe, just maybe, I can finally fix things, Adora thought to herself.

“Catra! Our scouts just reported the princess alliance’s combined forces marching onto our border! And according to my calculations, they’re heading for us!” Entrapta shouted at Catra. Catra stopped attacking the punching bag in the gym and turned around.

“What? They were supposed to attack tomorrow! Did Double Trouble give us bad information?” Catra asked. “Nevermind that, the townsfolk haven’t escaped yet! How much time do we have?” Entrapta studied her technology pad.

“About an hour!” Entrapta answered.

“Fuck. And most of the trucks haven’t arrived here from the towns they’re supposed to escape to! Send messages to those towns to stay out of this area, and have Rogelio and Kyle take a truckload of the town folks' children out of here, now!” Catra ordered. Entrapta nodded and raced off. Catra ran into the meeting room, and sounded the emergency alarm. Catra grabbed the town’s intercom system. “This stupid thing better work, Entrapta!”

“Attention citizens. Invading forces will arrive in approximately an hour. Round up all children and bring them to the main square to be evacuated. If you have proper mode of transportation, flee. If not, seek shelter in one of the safer buildings. Approved buildings include the library/school, the town hall, the storage units, and the small military base/gym. If you’re a soldier or any other part of our armed forces, report to battlestations within the next half-hour, and corral and aid civilians if need be. Thank you, and try to remain calm. The situation is under control,” Catra narrated in her most formal and monotone voice. She set down the mic as the other princesses arrived. Perfuma and Scorpia rushed in, followed by Netossa and a visibly pregnant Spinerella dragging Frosta along. Lonnie came in last, a sheaf of papers in hand.

“Catra! Is this all true?” Lonnie asked. Catra nodded.

“I just got word from Entrapta. Glimmer’s attacking a day early. Here’s what each of you need to do, and remember, DON’T FUCKING MESS THIS UP. Perfuma and Netossa, I need you to make some traps around town to slow down the advancing army. Frosta, I’ll need you to protect the truck with the village’s children on it. Scorpia and Lonnie, get the town's defenses ready, and Scorpia, power up some of the weapons. Spinerella, stay out of battle, because you’re, you know… pregnant, and instead serve as

our aerial scout to warn us and tell us of all army movements. Entrapta will be working on tech to get us ready, and Huntara is getting the army ready. I'll be helping her. Everyone understand?" Catra asked. The expressions on everyone's faces ranged from shocked to scared. Eventually, Catra got some head nods and muttered 'yeahs'. "Good. We don't have any time to waste. Let's go."

Catra slipped on her battle armor as she helped armor the other soldiers. Huntara sharpened her weapon of choice, a long spear. Catra's stomach quaked a little, though she'd never admit it. Then, the sound of a ping from her pad reached her ears. She glanced down at it. Spinerella's confirmation. The army was marching into their town. Catra glanced at the other soldiers, then gave them a nod.

"Let's go."

Adora couldn't stop panting by the time she reached the temple, having run all the way there. Even in She-ra form, exhaustion covered her like a heavy blanket. She sagged onto a wall and panted for a moment to catch her breath before heading in.

Her footsteps echoed over the crystalline floor, and she held up her sword. If her muscles were any more tense, they'd condense into solid rock. She made her way into the central chamber. Madame Razz's words came back to her 'I pull out the bad plants, but it's the soil that's the problem'. The First Ones had entrenched their tech deep into the earth. The infecting crystal probably drew power from the system of tech in the planet, allowing it to protect itself. So when you wanted to get rid of the problem, you had to pull it out by the roots.

Adora approached the altar, trying to take steadying breaths. Fuck. What if this doesn't work? Adora wondered, gripping her sword tighter. It has to. This has to work. And it will.

Adora stepped up to the altar, raised her sword, and pointed it at the crystal. She closed her eyes and let healing energies flow from the sword to the crystal. They seeped through the sword, into the crystal, and then to the interconnected system of First Ones tech below. It spread and grew, taking over the infection. Adora could feel the sickness of the infection, but forced herself to keep going. Closer… closer… closer...

Then, a blinding flash shot out of the altar, purging the infection. It was gone, finally. Finally. Adora stumbled back, the sudden release of magic a punch in the gut. But as she glanced back at the altar, the crystal cracked, then disintegrated into dust. Adora smiled, and for the first time in a long time, she let herself relax. Just for a few moments.

"Charge!" Catra ordered the council's army as Glimmer's troops advanced. The princess alliance braced itself for a charge, running forward, but they were about to be severely disappointed.

Archers shot bombs of all different kinds, scattering the charging army even more. Then, a few rounds of arrows fell down on them. To top it all off, troops began falling into traps as the council's army surrounded them, charging for real this time. Catra allowed herself a grin at her battle strategies working.

Catra ran forwards, running towards Glimmer with Scorpia and Perfuma covering her. In the background, Netossa and Huntara ran, charging into the army, taking down several soldiers at once.

Catra's vision honed in on Glimmer as she dodged past soldiers, knocking a few down on her way. She tried not to pay attention to the soldiers who fell at her hands, or the injuries that her claws scored. She tried not to turn back and see them fall to the ground. She tried not to turn back at all. Catra focused her gaze on Glimmer, tensing her muscles. Glimmer glanced towards her and grimaced.

A flash of sparkles exploded in front of her, interrupting her train of though, and Glimmer appeared. Glimmer smirked. A green bruise-or something like that- ran along Glimmer's arm, drawing Catra's eyes.

"Happy to see me, Catra?" Glimmer asked. Catra laughed.

"Not really, Sparkles," Catra replied. "Not really. Especially because you're attacking a civilian town who has done nothing to you." Catra sharpened her words.

"Excuse me? You were going to attack us! And this is a military base, not a civilian town! How do you explain all the soldiers?" Glimmer shot back.

"The soldiers are here because we heard about your plan and called our army to here. Look, around we're a civilian town! Are we the capital of our collective nation? Yes. But are we a fucking military base? NO," Catra responded. Glimmer cast her gaze towards the town, her eyes landing on the community garden, playground, and houses.

“You were going to attack us! We had to retaliate!”

“No, we fucking WEREN’T! Why the fuck would you think that?”

“You set up a guard around the border! Clearly, you were gathering intel for an attack?” Catra widened her eyes and stepped back. Then she burst into a fit of laughter.

“EXCUSE ME? First of all, if we were gathering intel, why wouldn’t we have ventured into your actual territory? Or, I don’t know, got some spies or maybe some fucking MAPS? Second of all, no, we set up the border guard because we thought you were going to attack us!” Glimmer opened her mouth then shut it again. Bow suddenly appeared behind Glimmer, in the midst of the fray.

“Glimmer! Are you okay?” Bow asked.

“I’m… I’m fine. But Catra just told me that she wasn’t planning to attack. And Bow, I looked around, and this is a civilian town. It has civilians in it,” Glimmer answered. “Fucking civilians.”

“See, Glimmer, please, like I’ve been telling you, just stop the attack you can still stop it. We’re losing, so please, just call it off,” Bow said, grabbing Glimmer’s hand and squeezing it. Glimmer looked around at her troops, who were falling victim to traps, being attacked by soldiers, or who lay in the field, already too injured to fight. Glimmer turned her gaze to Catra, and Catra swallowed.

“Look, Glimmer, please call off the attack. Please,” Catra begged. Glimmer hesitated for a few moments. Catra didn’t dare breathe.

“STOP THE ATTACK!” Glimmer screamed. Catra let out the breath, letting her muscles relax. A smile seemed to flash on Glimmer’s face. Then, she screamed, grabbing at her arm as the green bruise receded. Her eyes rolled back in her head, and she fell into Bow’s arm, limp. Fuck.

Wait, what happens next?

Adora stumbled onto the battlefield and her eyes widened. No.

Dead and dying people lay on the battlefield, some people hauling or carrying them away. Other people struggled to get away from the battlefield themselves, barely walking. Weapons lay on the ground, blood still coating them. Flies flew around, filling Adora's ear with their buzzing.

I couldn't stop it. Tears welled in Adora's eyes. I was too late. Too late, too late, too late. The words bounced around in her head, growing with each repetition. Every bit of her stayed in perfect stillness, not daring to move.

"She-ra?" Someone croaked. Adora turned around. A person with purple skin and a leg missing lay on the ground, looking up at her. "Is this a hallucination?" Adora suppressed a gag at the blood and pus caking on where their leg used to be. She sucked in a deep breath, banishing all other thoughts for a moment.

"No, it's not a hallucination. She-ra. Don't- urk- don't worry. I… I can heal this," Adora said, shaking as she sat down. She pressed her hand gently into the open wound, nearly throwing up.

Warm energies began to flow between them, and Adora kept pressing until the blood stopped flowing. Eventually, she fell back, with the person's wound mostly closed over. The person let out a long sigh, falling back on the ground.

"Thank you. Thank you, She-ra," The person said. A tear slid down Adora's cheek, and she nodded. I can still help. Everything's gone to shit, but I can still help.

"You're welcome," Adora replied, offering them a hand. But then someone else drew her attention. A salineas warrior, from the looks of it, with a gaping wound. And then another person needed healing. And then another and then another and then another-

“ADORA!” A familiar voice screamed. Bow. Adora turned to see him sprinting over just as she closed over another wound. She struggled to get up, but fell back down in the process. “Adora, are you okay? What are you doing here?”

“Bow! You’re alive! Thank Etheria,” Adora said, her voice hoarse. “I’m… I’m healing these people. I’m fine. But where are Glimmer and Catra?” Tears built up in Adora’s eyes. “Please tell me they’re okay. Please.” Bow hesitated.

“Catra is fine. She’s helping out with the recovery. Glimmer… not so much. She collapsed in battle. She’s in one of the med tents,” Bow replied. “But what happened to you?”

“That doesn’t matter. I’m fine. How long ago did she collapse, Bow?” Adora asked. Bow hesitated.

“I’m not sure… half an hour?” The blood rushed away from Adora’s face. Fuck.

“That… that was when I destroyed that First Ones virus. In the ruin. The one that infected Glimmer? How-how is she?”

“She’s stable.” Adora let out a breath. “For now, at least.”

“I need to help her.” Adora got up and tried to run, but fell down again, her legs weak. Seriously? I absorbed the magic at the heart of Etheria, and I STILL don’t have enough magical energy to just help my fucking friend?

“Adora, you can’t help her like this.”

“What if she dies? And it’s my fault?”

“Your fault for what? Healing those other people and using up your energy? For caring about people?” Adora looked down, tears pressing at her eyelids.

“Fuck. Just bring me to see her.” Bow hesitated, then nodded. He took a hold of Adora’s arm, and helped her across the battlefield.

Adora kept her eyes trained on the line of tents ahead, seeing through the tears that clogged her vision.

They stopped just in front of the med tent. Adora extended a trembling hand, then pulled it back.

"Adora," Bow said. "You wanted to see her." Adora nodded, wiping away her tears. She walked into the tent.

Glimmer lay on a cot, skin paler than a ghost's, Micah and Castaspella next to her. Adora hesitated. You just have to move one foot forward, then another, She remembered.

Then another, then another, and then another. She managed to walk over, a little more strength in her bones. Micah and Castaspella looked up, their eyes widening.

"Adora? Is that you?" Castaspella asked, her voice a hoarse whisper. Adora nodded, her gaze still fixed on Glimmer. "Well, we could certainly use you right now." She half laughed, but she gripped Glimmer's hand even tighter.

Adora used up most of her magic. She needs to rest and recover," Bow said, crossing his arms.

"I'm not sure I could help her that much even if I tried," Adora admitted. She shrugged as her heart broke in two looking at Glimmer lying on that cot. Micah stood up and looked them dead in the eye. His eyes watered.

"Adora. I need you to help my daughter. You'll survive healing her, but Glimmer won't survive this," Micah spoke up, his voice breaking. Adora stepped forward.

"You don't know that. She could survive and be fine!" Bow protested. But he hesitated. Just for a moment.

"If the majority of our sorcerers hadn't already used up most of their powers healing and fighting, she would survive on her own. If she hadn't worn herself out fighting, she would survive on her

own. If we could even transport her to Brightmoon so she could recharge, she would survive. But we can't do any of those things. So please, Adora, heal her," Micah begged, tears sliding down his cheeks. Adora swallowed.

"I'll heal her. But this isn't sacrificing myself. Glimmer is my best friend, but I'm not going to let myself die. I'll heal her to the best of my abilities… and then, well, we'll see." Micah nodded, and Adora raised her sword up, her arms straining, and then brought it down, nudging Glimmer. Warmth pooled at her core, and Adora surrounded herself with it, and then-

She pushed the energy into Glimmer. Something like a punch hit her stomach, and she doubled over. The world around her darkened as she fought to stay awake. The last thing she saw was color returning to Glimmer's skin. Adora let out a breath, and slipped into unconsciousness.

Catra paced besides Adora's bedside table, her tail lashing. Fuck, fuck, fuck. How could this have happened? How could Catra have let this happen? She glanced over to look at Adora, again and again and again. Adora lay there, still.

She sank down into a nearby chair, looking over at Adora. She took a deep breath. Air went in and out of her nostrils. In and out. In and out. Catra looked over at Adora again, pins and needles in her stomach. Her hand found its way to Adora's, reaching out, and Catra squeezed it, waiting.

Adora didn’t squeeze back. Of course she didn’t. Catra let out a sigh and leaned back in her chair, still clinging to Adora’s hand. Someone entered the tent, letting the tent flap fall behind them.

“Hey,” Glimmer said, shifting from foot to foot. Catra looked up.

“Glimmer,” Catra greeted. A moment of silence fell. Glimmer didn’t move. Neither did Catra.

“Is Adora okay?” Glimmer asked.

“Why would you care?” Catra snapped. Glimmer flinched. “Sorry.”

“No. I understand.” Catra bristled. “I might react the same way, in your place. Is she looking any better, at least?”

“She hasn’t really changed much in the past few hours.” Catra laughed, a bitter taste in her mouth. Glimmer sat down. More silence.

“I’m so sorry, Catra.” Catra squeezed Adora’s hand tighter.

“Sorry doesn’t cut it. You nearly invaded a civilian town.”

“Is that really why you’re angry?” Catra turned around and glared at Glimmer.

“Excuse me?”

“Are you mad because of the invasion, or are you mad because Adora healed me?” Catra didn’t say anything. “Look, I’m so sorry for the invasion, and I know that sounds really dumb. But I am, Catra. I am sorry. When I look back… I understand why you left. And I understand why you’re angry now. So I’m sorry. For everything.”

“But?”

“But nothing. I’m just sorry.” A tear rolled out of Catra’s eyes, and she wiped it away. “Where’s melog? He’s your support animal,

right?”

“Yeah. I wanted to be alone with Adora.”

“Oh. Do you want me to leave?”

“No.”

“Do you want me to get you something to drink or eat? You’ve been here for hours.”

“Yes.” Catra kept looking down as Glimmer walked out, her boots crunching against the pebble ground of the medtent. Catra looked at Adora again, squeezing her hand. “I love you, Adora. I know you can’t hear me, but I love you. And I’m sorry.”

“I love you, Adora. I know you can’t hear me, but I love you. And I’m sorry.” Those words rolled through Adora’s head as she rose out of the darkness.

The words took a couple of seconds to sink in, her head spinning. Catra. That was Catra’s voice. The feeling of someone squeezing her hand slowly sunk in.

Adora blinked her eyes open, and saw Catra sitting next to her. Catra turned her head and her eyes widened.

“Adora?” Catra whispered, her voice hoarse.

“Catra,” Adora replied, smiling.

“You’re awake! How? What happened?” Catra asked. Adora tried to shrug, then winced at the ache in her shoulders.

“Fuck that hurts. I… don’t know. I just heard you.” Catra flattened her ears, blushing.

“You heard all of that?”

“Yeah.” Catra tried to hide her flaming blush. “I love you too.”

“Adora, I’m… I’m sorry. I don’t know quite how to put it, given everything that I’ve done. Especially for what I said the last time I saw you. Bow told everything that happened with Glimmer. I can’t even imagine what you were going through. I can’t BELIEVE I was so insensitive! I’m so sorry.”

“No, I’M sorry. I should never have compared you to Shadow Weaver. You didn’t deserve it at all.” Adora looked Catra right in the eyes, putting as much meaning behind her words as she could.

“Maybe… maybe I did. I mean, I was pretty horrible to you…” Catra half-laughed, her eyes beginning to glisten.

“No, you didn’t, Catra! You didn’t deserve that at all.” Catra sat for a moment, then nodded. She wiped the tears from her eyes. Catra smiled at Adora, and Adora grinned back, a bit of warmth gathering in her chest.

“You’re right. I didn’t deserve that. But I am sorry. And I want to apologize. I’m so sorry for what I said to you when we last saw each other. I’m so sorry for what I did, and I can’t believe what I said and did...” Catra stopped, tears flowing down her cheek, and Adora squeezed her hand.

“Thank you. And I’m sorry for pressuring you to leave, especially when I had no idea what you were going through. But most of all, I’m sorry for leaving you. I left you, Adora. Not the other way around. And I can’t believe I did it.” Catra let out a sob, and Adora reached out to put a hand on her back, aches and pains be damned.

“You should have left. And maybe I should have too. Maybe. I don’t know. But you weren’t wrong for leaving, Catra. I’m sorry I never came with you. I thought I had to fix things, that I had to get things done and push through. I didn’t. And I’m sorry, Catra. I’m sorry.”

“I’m still mad at you for not coming with you. I know it’s stupid, I know it’s silly, but I’m stilly angry. And I can’t help it. But I love you, and I think, someday I’ll stop being so mad. Because you’re kind, and loyal, and you care so much about everything, and I love you for that. And I know you’re not the only one at fault. I can’t say forgive you, but I can say I love you.” Catra looked into Adora’s eyes, which were welling up. A crescendo of emotions played in Adora’s heart, building and rising and playing an indescribable melody.

“Thank you. I’m still angry at you too. But I’m going to piggyback off of what you said and say I love you. So much. To all of Etheria’s moons and back, in fact.” Catra rolled her eyes.

“You’re really going to steal my poetic speech?” Adora smiled and shrugged.

“Maaaaybe?” They both burst out laughing. Adora laughed until her stomach hurt. “To be fair, saying I love you to all of Etheria’s moons and back is pretty much my poetic speech potential.”

“Idiot.”

“And you know it.” Catra leaned in and pressed Adora’s lips to hers. Energy spread all over Adora’s body, encasing her in warmth. Adora leaned in and kissed her harder, grabbing the nape of Catra’s neck. Catra tucked a piece of Adora’s hair back. They pulled apart after a few moments, blushing and smiling.

“So,” Adora wondered. “What happens next?”

“Are you ready?” Catra asked, glancing out of the tent onto the stage it lay on. Crowds waited in front of it, whispering and wondering. Butterflies tickled at Adora’s stomach, and she clutched it, suppressing her gag instinct.

“Yeah. I can do this. I can do this,” Adora reassured herself. “But what if I mess it up? Or forget my lines? Half of Etheria is at this festival! We have to make the kick-off speech perfect! What if not everyone hears me?” Catra rolled her eyes.

“Adora. You’re She-ra. Everyone will love you. And you have that weird broadcaster thing Entrapta made. And you’ve been practicing your speech for weeks. Just go out there, and say it already,” Catra said. Adora nodded, but hesitated, fidgeting with a nearby piece of paper.

“Can I get a goodluck kiss?”

“Of course, dummy.” Catra leaned in and kissed Adora for a few blissful seconds cut off too short. Adora’s face heated, some of the tickling in her stomach fading.

“Wish me luck!”

“You know I will.” Adora pulled away from Catra, and stepped onto the stage, riding high from adrenaline. The people’s cheers deafened her ears. Adora couldn’t help but grin.

“Hi-hi everyone. As you know, I’m She-ra, and…” Adora trailed off as she noticed Catra smiling at her from the tent. Adora smiled back and spoke again.

“As you all know, we had a horrific battle three months ago. Over a dozen lives were lost. It was a blight on the history of Etheria. But I can promise you, we will- and are already- rebuild. And we will rebuild better. As She-ra, I will be traveling around Etheria,

helping the citizens of New Etheria to rebuild and recover. Our esteemed council of Etheria has detailed several plans to help the citizens of Etheria. First, we are creating a high-tech transportation system that will stretch all around Etheria, made up of boats and land transportation vehicles. And for these vehicles, we are making a series of seaways and roads all across our world! We are also planning to create community buildings in every town across Etheria, no matter how small. The community buildings include libraries, schools, counseling centers, gyms, and public records offices. And furthermore, we are creating a system that will bring free water, food, and housing to ALL etherians, at no cost. And what do we ask of you? All we ask is that you simply work 20 hours a week, or more if you wish, to help your communities. We have gone through hard times in Etheria, but WE WILL BUILD BACK BETTER!" The audience started clapping, a thunderous applause that swept through the entire festival grounds. Catra smiled and stepped onto the stage.

"With that great welcome from our new co-council leader, I'd like to invite the new councilmembers to the stage," Catra said. Mermista, Bow, Micah, Glimmer, and Seahawk stepped out onto the stage.

"Mermista, I appoint you the council member of the Sea and Fishing." Mermista grinned and stepped forward, out of Seahawk's embrace.

"Bow, I appoint you councilmember of social services and counseling." Bow beamed and took a step forward, but not before Glimmer kissed him on the cheek, widening his beaming smile.

"Micah, I appoint you the councillor of magic." Micah nodded, walking up next to bow.

"Glimmer, I appoint you the new councillor of communications and travel. Spinerella will be the councillor of education." Glimmer grinned and walked ahead.

“Seahawk, I…” Catra’s face contorted, and she let out a laugh. “Seahawk, I appoint you councillor of adventure and fire safety. Of all things. You’re not included in council meetings, by the way. It’s an honorary title only.” Seahawk beamed, leaping forward and hugging Mermista, planting a kiss on her cheek. Adora chuckled.

“What do you think of that, my dearest Mermista?” He asked, taking her hand and kissing it. Mermista rolled her eyes, but everyone could see her flaming red cheeks.

“Councillor of Fire Safety, huh? Sure hope that won’t backfire,” Adora commented. Catra rolled her eyes.

“You know it will, idiot,” Catra replied, reaching an arm around Adora’s shoulders. Adora flushed, her cheeks heating.

“Without further ado, let the festival begin!” Catra announced, throwing her arms up and grinning. The crowd, roared, a thunderous cheer that drowned out all else. Catra turned to Adora and grinned, winking.

“Hey, Adora.”

Catra and Adora held hands as they strolled through the festival, sneaking glances and kisses. Warmth filled Catra. Rides, games, souvenir shops, food stalls, music, plays, dancing, and entertainers gathered all around. The smell of festival snacks filled Catra’s nose, tickling at her stomach.

Just as they leaned together for another kiss, Catra’s stomach rumbled, aching all around her midsection. Catra’s face heated. But Adora kept her goofy grin.

“Want to get some food? OOH! I saw a cloud candy place back there! And some fried and battered fish on a stick! Plus, I saw a vendor selling fresh flower fruit!” Adora suggested, her words jumbling together. Catra rolled her eyes, laughing softly. Adora put her hands together, her eyes getting huge and watery. “Can we pleaaaase get a bunch of food? Pleaaaase? You’re the one who’s hungry!”

“Fine, but if you throw up, I won’t be held accountable.”

Adora retched, emptying her stomach of its contents, Catra holding her hair. Gagging sounds emerged from the trashcan Adora stuck her face in, and Catra wrinkled her nose as the smell reached her nostrils. Eventually, Adora stopped, sinking down against the trashcan and sighing out.

“So. What do you want to do next?” Adora asked, her eyes flashing with light. Catra threw her hands up in the air.

“Adora. You just threw up. Shouldn’t you, I don’t know, TAKE A BREAK?” Catra replied, crossing her arms. Adora stared at her for a moment.

“So… do you want to watch more fire-eaters?” Adora asked.

“Alright, Adora, let’s see. We’ve watched TWO fire-eaters, watched an entire play written and acted by Double Trouble, eaten enough food to make you throw up, gotten souvenirs, played for festival prizes, listened to the bands, danced, watched entertainers, gone to the exhibits, and to the petting zoo, but we haven’t gone on a single ride,” Catra pointed out. “Are you deliberately avoiding the rides?”

“Whaaaaaaat? I love rollercoasters! I’m not scared of them!”

“You’re scared of rollercoasters?” Laughter bubbled in Catra’s chest.

“They’re dangerous death machines! Who designs them? How do we know they work? How do we know they won’t kill us all?”

“How do we know they won’t bring about the end of civilization itself?”

“Exactly!” Catra snorted, suppressing a laugh.

“Adora… hundreds of people have been on the rollercoaster already just today. I’m sure it’ll be fine.” Adora straightened up a little bit.

“It’s not stupid! I get scared sometimes. Not like you.” Catra hesitated.

“Ugh. If I tell you something, do you promise not to tell anyone else?”

“Absolutely! You can trust me! I am like, the best at secrets.”

“Okay, princess. When we… when we arrived in Etheria, I was… urgh. Never mind.”

“No, no, you can tell me!” Adora’s wide and stupid grin radiated warmth.

“Fine, I guess. I was… scared of waterfalls.”

“What?”

“I WAS SCARED OF WATERFALLS! Okay? In my defense, waterfalls are really weird! And one time in the Horde, I nearly fell over one with Glimmer and Bow! Waterfalls are terrifying acts of nature!”

“Wait, what? YOU were scared of something?”

“Hard to believe, I know.”

“Seriously?”

“Seriously.”

“I can’t believe this. So I’m not the total wimp in our relationship?”

“Oh, trust me, you still are.” Adora hesitated, then looked at Catra, fidgeting with her shirt.

“Rollercoasters may be evil death machines… but maaaybe I could ride one if you came with me?” Adora smiled, sweetness pouring out of every corner of her being.

“Absolutely.”

“You ready?” Catra asked Adora. Adora nodded, squeezing Catra’s hand tightly enough to cut off circulation.

“Not like we can turn back now, huh? Actually, can we turn back now? Because I really, really want to,” Adora replied. But the rollercoaster kept inching up the track, moving towards the first peak.

“Nope. And I’m going to enjoy every minute of this rollercoaster ride,” Catra said, putting her hands up in the air and grinning.

“We’re gonna die, we’re gonna die, we’re go-AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHH!” Adora screamed as they rushed down over the first hill at top speed, a rocket with all their thrusters engaged. Catra whooped as the winds blew through

their hair and the pit of her stomach dropped. The rollercoaster raced up and down the hills, scrambling everyone's brains on the way. Delicious electricity crackled in Catra's stomach as she plunged up and down on the rollercoaster.

The rollercoaster screeched and whirred around the track, finally coming to a halting stop. Catra glanced over at Adora, whose skin had blanched, with her hair whipped all over her face. Catra snickered and wiped a strand of hair from Adora's lips. They got out of the rollercoaster car and collapsed onto a nearby park bench.

"Surprised we didn't die?" Catra asked.

"Very. But the moments when I wasn't sure were my favorites," Adora said. "Can we do it again?" Catra rolled her eyes.

"How about we wait a little while? I am not holding your hair while you throw up again," Catra warned. Adora grinned.

"I love you, Catra," She said. A smile spread across Catra's face.

"I love you too." Catra leaned down, and kissed Adora's forehead. Adora blushed while Catra slipped an arm around her shoulder. They sat there for a moment, just watching the fair move around them.

"Catra! Adora!" Some screeched. Their heads whipped around to see Mermista running after them. Adora shot up.

"What is it?" She asked. Mermista stopped in front of them, panting.

"Spinerella… Spinerella is in labor and I can't deal with it! I need you two to come with me, now!" Mermista ordered.

"Fuck," Was all Catra could say.

“Do you know what we’re supposed to do?” Adora whispered to Catra.

“I think we’re supposed to be moral support for Mermista. To be fair, if I had to deal with Seahawk and a lady in labor at the same time, I’d need moral support too,” Catra replied.

“WHAT IF WE SET THE TENT ON FIRE?” Seahawk yelled.

“THAT’S NOT GOING TO HELP!” Mermista yelled back.

“So, Mermista… what exactly are we supposed to be doing?” Adora asked. Mermista whirled around to look at Adora.

“I have no idea. Maybe, I don’t know, STOP MY SUPER ANNOYING BOYFRIEND FROM TERRORIZING SPINERELLA?” Mermista directed that last part at Seahawk.

“My dearest Mermista! You see me as your boyfriend?” Seahawk asked, his eyes lighting up.

“URGH, I regret everything. Adora, just… do something. I don’t know,” Mermista said, massaging her brow. Adora hesitated, turning her head from one way to another. She grabbed a stress ball.

“I’m going to… bring this into Spinerella and come check on her,” Adora said inching out of the room.

“Good luck,” Catra said. “From what I’ve heard, Spinerella is NOT a happy camper. Scorpia had to take Frosta to ‘explore the festival’, it got so ugly. Huntara is ‘guarding the tent’. She’s definitely not hiding from Spinerella’s wrath.”

Adora swallowed hard and slid into the tent where Spinerella lay.

Netossa and Bow lay on the left side of Spinerella, with Netossa holding her hand. Perfuma stood off to the side, mixing together herbs. Entrapta and Micah lay on the right side of her, comparing… notes? Castaspella and Glimmer created different runes in the air.

"You can do it!" Bow encouraged Spinerella, who had sweat dripping all down her face. Spinerella growled.

"Come on sweetie… you can push through this," Netossa said, clearly on pins and needles.

"Shut up or I WILL commit murder when I'm done with this," Spinerella muttered, her eyes flashing. Netossa shrunk back.

"Now, my data says that the estimated time for this birth would be 2.4 hours," Entrapta muttered.

"What? My Angella took ten hours to give birth!" Micah exclaimed.

"I had better not be taking ten fucking hours to give birth!" Spinerella screamed. Netossa winced.

"Better double down on those soundproofing runes, Glimmer," Castaspella instructed. Glimmer nodded, creating more runes. "And we still have yet to make a proper pain relief spell!"

"You should use my natural medicines! No-one ever tries them, but they work, I swear!" Perfuma said. Voices overlapped over one another, with shouts, whispers, and snapping all around. Adora squeezed the stressball, hard.

"Everyone, stop what you're doing!" Adora ordered. Everyone snapped up, staring. "Spinerella needs the best care possible! Bow and Netossa, try to be silent supporters of Spinerella. Entrapta, use your science trackerpad thingy to determine what medical care to give Spinerella. Micah, go help Castaspella and Glimmer formulate a good pain relief spell OUTSIDE the tent. Come back in

when you're done. Perfuma, feel free to mix those herbs, but please leave the tent. Everybody understand?" Adora waited a moment, and saw a few head nods. "Good! Now actually GO."

Adora stumbled out of the tent, exhausted. Catra smiled and caught her. Adora smiled back weakly. A warmth gathered in Catra's chest as she brought Adora down to sit.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said.

"Hey, Catra," Adora replied. They grinned.

"What's going on with Spinerella?" Catra asked.

"She's almost ready to give birth. I had to step back because it was about to get really messy," Adora said. Catra snickered.

"I thought all that field research you did prepared you."

"Nothing could have prepared me for childbirth. It's a warzone in there. I would prefer to fight against an army of evil angry aliens than have to face childbirth." Catra had to laugh at Adora's gaunt face and dark tone.

"In that case, good job, Force Captain." Their hands found each other and intertwined. They stayed there for a moment.

Then, Bow burst through the tent flap.

"She's given birth! And it's TWINS!" Bow squealed. Catra's ear perked up, and she and Adora both stood up.

"WHAT?" Adora asked. She raced into the tent, and Catra followed her. She pushed through the tent flap to see Spinerella cradling two adorable little babies. One had dark brown skin with frizzy

pink hair, and the other had light brown skin with gently curling blue hair.

"Oh…" Catra trailed off as something seized her chest. Catra stopped in her tracks. The scene was a tapestry from one of Etheria's finest weavers. A weaver who could weave in every emotion and feeling on the planet. Spinerella and Netossa's expressions radiated sunlight as they cradled their babies.

"They're both female. The second one came out two minutes after the first one," Bow whispered to Adora and Catra. Spinerella looked up, still smiling.

"These kids almost make labor worth it. Almost," Spinerella joked.

"Have you decided on names yet? You should give them nature names!" Perfuma suggested. Spinerella looked down at the two girls and smiled.

"Actually, we've already chosen their names. Do you want to do the honors, Netossa?" Spinerella clasped Netossa's hand.

"We've decided to name them…" Netossa trailed off.

"Stop milking it for dramatic effect. I've had to deal with Seahawk freaking out for two hours straight. Get to the fucking point," Mermista ordered, rubbing her brow.

"We've decided to name them Adora and Catra, after our heroes," Netossa said. Catra stepped back, her eyes widening.

"Really? You named them for us? Me and Adora right here?" She asked. Tears began to gather in her eyes. Adora put her hand on Catra's shoulder and smiled. "Thank you."

"Of course. We also thought you could be their godmothers?" Spinerella asked.

"Are you kidding? Of course we will! ...Can we hold them?" Adora asked. Spinerella nodded and held them out. Catra reached out,

her fingers extending towards them, until she held one of them in her arms. The soft skin of the baby brushed against her arms, and the warmth of the baby sunk into her own skin. She looked up and smiled.

“They’re so perfect,” She said, tears clouding her vision.

“They are,” Netossa said. “They are.”

The golden rays of the sun covered the fair grounds as Catra and Adora stared out at the horizon, sitting on a bench.

“This day has been a rollercoaster. Get it? Rollercoaster? Because we went on a rollercoaster?” Adora joked. Catra giggled, leaning onto Adora.

“Maybe… you would want it to be a little more of a rollercoaster?” Catra asked, fiddling with her hands. Electricity tickled at her stomach. She stood up.

“Wait, what?” Adora asked, cocking her head. Catra took a deep breath, every nerve in her body on edge.

“Adora, will you…” Catra trailed off, then took in a breath. “Adora, I love you, and I want to spend every single second of the rest of my life with you. You’re funny, kind, and so earnest it’s annoying. And you’re a total idiot. But I love you more than I’ve ever loved anyone before. So Adora, will you marry me?” By now, Adora’s eyes were filled with tears, and her hands covered her mouth.

“Yes! Yes, I want to marry you! Oh my god. Oh my god.” Tears started flowing in Catra’s eyes, and they embraced, arms wrapping around each other, enveloping each other. “Thank you, Catra. Thank you so much.”

Adora’s warm, familiar scent filled Catra’s nose, and she hugged her closer, losing herself in Adora for a moment. They looked at each other. Adora’s blue eyes glinted in the fading sunlight, an ocean in her eye. Something filled up Catra, from top to bottom. Their lips met, and they lost themselves in each other, together forever and always.

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